

PLAGUE DIARIES: FIRSTHAND ACCOUNTS OF EPIDEMICS, 430 B.C. TO A.D. 1918



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Plague Diaries: Firsthand Accounts of Epidemics, 430 B.C. to A.D. 1918

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Note to Faculty

This project originated in response to the Covid-19 pandemic sweeping the globe and its various knock-on effects. We created a small collection of openly available primary documents discussing epidemics from the past, such as the Black Death in Europe in the mid-fourteenth century and smallpox hitting northern Michigan in the nineteenth.

Our initial goal was to highlight similarities between past outbreaks and modern ones, including Covid-19. To that end, there are questions presented at the end of each source that inquire about parallels that can be drawn between then and now. There are also questions designed to explore similarities between the various sources themselves, to highlight patterns that can be seen across time. Our hope is that this collection will be useful not just for history classes, but also for political science, anthropology, psychology, and perhaps some of the hard sciences as well.

Although illustrating parallels was the primary objective of this project, we recognize that forced comparisons between the past and the present are problematic. We also recognize, and hope any faculty members who choose to utilize this collection also recognize, that as much can be learned from historical contrasts as can be learned from historical comparisons. For instance, though there are some similarities between the Covid-19 outbreak and the bubonic plague of the fourteenth century, there are also crucial differences in the contexts in which those diseases spread. Studying those differences helps us understand what happened in the 1300s and why, as well as what's happening now and why. You'll find that in addition to questions highlighting parallels, there are also questions that aim to uncover differences between the events of the past and those of the present.

We sincerely hope you find this resource helpful, and are excited to see the creative ways faculty will put this collection to good use.

Ryan Johnson

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

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1.1: “Such was the history of the plague-” from History of the Peloponnesian War

“Such was the history of the plague:” from History of the Peloponnesian War

By Thucydides

Introduction:

The following excerpt comes from the ancient Greek historian Thucydides’ History of the Peloponnesian War . The war broke out in 431 BCE, and pitted Sparta against Athens, the two strongest city-states in Greece after the stunning victory against the Persian Empire roughly 70 years prior. After the Persian Wars, Athens had led the creation of a defensive alliance called the Delian League, the purpose of which was to be on the lookout for another Persian invasion. However, as years went on and no invasion materialized, some members of the League wanted to pull out. Athens would have none of it and bullied members into remaining part of the League, and used money that was supposed to be for the common defense to beautify Athens. Sparta, meanwhile, was becoming more anxious at this growing Athenian power, and when Athens began threatening some of Sparta’s allies on the Greek mainland, conflict ensued.

A year into the war, as Spartan armies ravaged the countryside around Athens, a plague hit the city. Estimates place the death toll between 75,000 and 100,000, including the city-state’s leader, Pericles, a loss that would have serious ramifications for the rest of the war. What precisely the disease was, we’re not entirely sure. Most likely, from Thucydides’ description, it was either smallpox or typhus. Some historians take Thucydides’ use of the word “plague” literally, and have asserted that bubonic plague was what hit Athens. Whatever the disease was, it afflicted tens of thousands of people, including Thucydides himself, who can therefore speak from a position of direct experience of the illness.

Such was the funeral that took place during this winter, with which the first year of the war came to an end. In the first days of summer the Lacedaemonians and their allies, with two-thirds of their forces as before, invaded Attica, under the command of Archidamus, son of Zeuxidamus, King of Lacedaemon, and sat down and laid waste the country. Not many days after their arrival in Attica the plague first began to show itself among the Athenians. It was said that it had broken out in many places previously in the neighbourhood of Lemnos and elsewhere; but a pestilence of such extent and mortality was nowhere remembered. Neither were the physicians at first of any service, ignorant as they were of the proper way to treat it, but they died themselves the most thickly, as they visited the sick most often; nor did any human art succeed any better. Supplications in the temples, divinations, and so forth were found equally futile, till the overwhelming nature of the disaster at last put a stop to them altogether.

It first began, it is said, in the parts of Ethiopia above Egypt, and thence descended into Egypt and Libya and into most of the King’s country. Suddenly falling upon Athens, it first attacked the population in Piraeus—which was the occasion of their saying that the Peloponnesians had poisoned the reservoirs, there being as yet no wells there—and afterwards appeared in the upper city, when the deaths became much more frequent. All speculation as to its origin and its causes, if causes can be found adequate to produce so great a disturbance, I leave to other writers, whether lay or professional; for myself, I shall simply set down its nature, and explain the symptoms by which perhaps it may be recognized by the student, if it should ever break out again. This I can the better do, as I had the disease myself, and watched its operation in the case of others.



“Thucydides” by Zde / CC BY-SA 4.0

That year then is admitted to have been otherwise unprecedentedly free from sickness; and such few cases as occurred all determined in this. As a rule, however, there was no ostensible cause; but people in good health were all of a sudden attacked by violent heats in the head, and redness and inflammation in the eyes, the inward parts, such as the throat or tongue, becoming bloody and emitting an unnatural and fetid breath. These symptoms were followed by sneezing and hoarseness, after which the pain soon reached the chest, and produced a hard cough. When it fixed in the stomach, it upset it; and discharges of bile of every kind named by physicians ensued, accompanied by very great distress. In most cases also an ineffectual retching followed, producing violent spasms, which in some cases ceased soon after, in others much later. Externally the body was not very hot to the touch, nor pale in its appearance, but reddish, livid, and breaking out into small pustules and ulcers. But internally it burned so that the patient could not bear to have on him clothing or linen even of the very lightest description; or indeed to be otherwise than stark naked. What they would have liked best would have been to throw themselves into cold water; as indeed was done by some of the neglected sick, who plunged into the rain-tanks in their agonies of unquenchable thirst; though it made no difference whether they drank little or much. Besides this, the miserable feeling of not being able to rest or sleep never ceased to torment them. The body meanwhile did not waste away so long as the distemper was at its height, but held out to a marvel against its ravages; so that when they succumbed, as in most cases, on the seventh or eighth day to the internal inflammation, they had still some strength in them. But if they passed this stage, and the disease descended further into the bowels, inducing a violent ulceration there accompanied by severe diarrhoea, this brought on a weakness which was generally fatal. For the disorder first settled in the head, ran its course from thence through the whole of the body, and, even where it did not prove mortal, it still left its mark on the extremities; for it settled in the privy parts, the fingers and the toes, and many escaped with the loss of these, some too with that of their eyes. Others again were seized with an entire loss of memory on their first recovery, and did not know either themselves or their friends.

But while the nature of the distemper was such as to baffle all description, and its attacks almost too grievous for human nature to endure, it was still in the following circumstance that its difference from all ordinary disorders was most clearly shown. All the birds and beasts that prey upon human bodies, either abstained from touching them (though there were many lying unburied), or died after tasting them. In proof of this, it was noticed that birds of this kind actually disappeared; they were not about the bodies, or indeed to be seen at all. But of course the effects which I have mentioned could best be studied in a domestic animal like the dog.

Such then, if we pass over the varieties of particular cases which were many and peculiar, were the general features of the distemper. Meanwhile the town enjoyed an immunity from all the ordinary disorders; or if any case occurred, it ended in this. Some died in neglect, others in the midst of every attention. No remedy was found that could be used as a specific; for what did good in one case, did harm in another. Strong and weak constitutions proved equally incapable of resistance, all alike being swept away, although dieted with the utmost precaution. By far the most terrible feature in the malady was the dejection which ensued when any one felt himself sickening, for the despair into which they instantly fell took away their power of resistance, and left them a much easier prey to the disorder; besides which, there was the awful spectacle of men dying like sheep, through having caught the infection in nursing each other. This caused the greatest mortality. On the one hand, if they were afraid to visit each other, they perished from neglect; indeed many houses were emptied of their inmates for want of a nurse: on the other, if they ventured to do so, death was the consequence. This was especially the case with such as made any pretensions to goodness: honour made them unsparing of themselves in their attendance in their friends' houses, where even the members of the family were at last worn out by the moans of the dying, and succumbed to the force of the disaster. Yet it was with those who had recovered from the disease that the sick and the dying found most compassion. These knew what it was from experience, and had now no fear for themselves; for the same man was never attacked twice—never at least fatally. And such persons not only received the congratulations of others, but themselves also, in the elation of the moment, half entertained the vain hope that they were for the future safe from any disease whatsoever.



"Plague in an Ancient City" by Michiel Sweerts / Public domain

An aggravation of the existing calamity was the influx from the country into the city, and this was especially felt by the new arrivals. As there were no houses to receive them, they had to be lodged at the hot season of the year in stifling cabins, where the mortality raged without restraint. The bodies of dying men lay one upon another, and half-dead creatures reeled about the streets and gathered round all the fountains in their longing for water. The sacred places also in which they had quartered themselves were full of corpses of persons that had died there, just as they were; for as the disaster passed all bounds, men, not knowing what was to become of them, became utterly careless of everything, whether sacred or profane. All the burial rites before in use were entirely upset, and they buried the bodies as best they could. Many from want of the proper appliances, through so many of their friends having died already, had recourse to the most shameless sepultures: sometimes getting the start of those who had raised a pile, they threw their own dead body upon the stranger's pyre and ignited it; sometimes they tossed the corpse which they were carrying on the top of another that was burning, and so went off.

Nor was this the only form of lawless extravagance which owed its origin to the plague. Men now coolly ventured on what they had formerly done in a corner, and not just as they pleased, seeing the rapid transitions produced by persons in prosperity suddenly dying and those who before had nothing succeeding to their property. So they resolved to spend quickly and enjoy themselves, regarding their lives and riches as alike things of a day. Perseverance in what men called honour was popular with none, it was so uncertain whether they would be spared to attain the object; but it was settled that present enjoyment, and all that contributed to it, was both honourable and useful. Fear of gods or law of man there was none to restrain them. As for the first, they judged it to be just the same whether they worshipped them or not, as they saw all alike perishing; and for the last, no one expected to live to be brought to trial for his offences, but each felt that a far severer sentence had been already passed upon them all and hung ever over their heads, and before this fell it was only reasonable to enjoy life a little.

Such was the nature of the calamity, and heavily did it weigh on the Athenians; death raging within the city and devastation without. Among other things which they remembered in their distress was, very naturally, the following verse which the old men said had long ago been uttered:

A Dorian war shall come and with it death.

So a dispute arose as to whether dearth and not death had not been the word in the verse; but at the present juncture, it was of course decided in favour of the latter; for the people made their recollection fit in with their sufferings. I fancy, however, that if another Dorian war should ever afterwards come upon us, and a dearth should happen to accompany it, the verse will probably be read accordingly. The oracle also which had been given to the Lacedaemonians was now remembered by those who knew of it. When the god was asked whether they should go to war, he answered that if they put their might into it, victory would be theirs, and that he would himself be with them. With this oracle events were supposed to tally. For the plague broke out as soon as the Peloponnesians invaded Attica, and never entering Peloponnese (not at least to an extent worth noticing), committed its worst ravages at Athens, and next to Athens, at the most populous of the other towns. Such was the history of the plague.

Glossary:

- Attica - the peninsula of which Athens is a part.
- dearth - an era or period in which food is scarce; famine.
- distemper - a term for one's humors being imbalanced; disease or disorder.
- Dorian - one of the ethnic groups that Classical Greece was divided into containing Sparta, Corinth, and Rhodes among others.
- Lacedaemonians - the term for Spartans in antiquity.
- Lemnos - a large island in the northern Aegean Sea, near the coast of Turkey.
- oracle - a priestess of various gods that would perform divinations to tell the future.
- Peloponnesians - people from the Peloponnese, a peninsula of southern Greece, which contains the city states of Sparta among others.
- Piraeus - a suburb or subdivision of Athens that served as its port.
- pustules - a pimple or bump filled with pus.
- sepultures - also spelled "sepulchres," a carved out burial cavern.
- supplications - prayers asking for something, sometimes including sacrifices.

Questions:

1. Compare and contrast the symptoms of this plague with those of Covid-19.
2. What psychological impact did this plague have on people, according to Thucydides? Do you see any similarities between what Thucydides relates and how people have reacted to modern epidemics? What are those similarities?
3. How did funeral rites change during this epidemic, and how does that compare to what we're seeing now?

Sources:

Mark, Joshua J. " [Thucydides on the Plague of Athens: Text & Commentary](#) ." Ancient History Encyclopedia. Ancient History Encyclopedia, 01 Apr 2020. Web. 20 Apr 2020.

"Thucydides, The Peloponnesian War." Perseus Digital Library, Tufts University, www.perseus.tufts.edu/hopper/text?doc=Perseus%3Atext%3A1999.01.0200%3Abook%3D2%3Achapter%3D47 .



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1.2: “During these times there was a pestilence-” History of the Wars

“During these times there was a pestilence:” History of the Wars

By Procopius

Introduction:

In 542 CE, during the reign of the Eastern Roman Emperor Justinian, plague hit the capital city of Constantinople. This plague was bubonic plague, the same type that would devastate Europe centuries later. This version of plague would last in the capital for four months, but would repeatedly strike the Mediterranean until 750 CE. 5,000 people per day were dying in Constantinople, and millions of people across the Eastern Roman Empire would die from the illness.

The disease originated in China and made its way west via trade routes. First afflicted Ethiopia, the disease travelled north into Egypt, from which it hopped aboard trade ships and moved both east and west. Trade routes and supply lines to the armies Justinian had sent out to reconquer parts of the former Western Roman Empire provided lanes through which the disease could spread. In the following excerpt, Justinian’s official historian, Procopius, tells us of the plague’s numerous symptoms, the economic impact of the sickness, as well as changes in funeral rites due to the plague.

XXII

542 A.D. During these times there was a pestilence, by which the whole human race came near to being annihilated. Now in the case of all other scourges sent from Heaven some explanation of a cause might be given by daring men, such as the many theories propounded by those who are clever in these matters; for they love to conjure up causes which are absolutely incomprehensible to man, and to fabricate outlandish theories of natural philosophy, knowing well that they are saying nothing sound, but considering it sufficient for them, if they completely deceive by their argument some of those whom they meet and persuade them to their view. But for this calamity it is quite impossible either to express in words or to conceive in thought any explanation, except indeed to refer it to God. For it did not come in a part of the world nor upon certain men, nor did it confine itself to any season of the year, so that from such circumstances it might be possible to find subtle explanations of a cause, but it embraced the entire world, and blighted the lives of all men, though differing from one another in the most marked degree, respecting neither sex nor age. For much as men differ with regard to places in which they live, or in the law of their daily life, or in natural bent, or in active pursuits, or in whatever else man differs from man, in the case of this disease alone the difference availed naught. And it attacked some in the summer season, others in the winter, and still others at the other times of the year. Now let each one express his own judgment concerning the matter, both sophist and astrologer, but as for me, I shall proceed to tell where this disease originated and the manner in which it destroyed men.

It started from the Aegyptians who dwell in Pelusium. Then it divided and moved in one direction towards Alexandria and the rest of Aegypt, and in the other direction it came to Palestine on the borders of Aegypt; and from there it spread over the whole world, always moving forward and travelling at times favourable to it. For it seemed to move by fixed arrangement, and to tarry for a specified time in each country, casting its blight slightly upon none, but spreading in either direction right out to the ends of the world, as if fearing lest some corner of the earth might escape it. For it left neither island nor cave nor mountain ridge which had human inhabitants; and if it had passed by any land, either not affecting the men there or touching them in indifferent fashion, still at a later time it came back; then those who dwelt round about this land, whom formerly it had afflicted most sorely, it did not touch at all, but it did not remove from the place in question until it had given up its just and proper tale of dead, so as to correspond exactly to the number destroyed at the earlier time among those who dwelt round about. And this disease always took its start from the coast, and from there went up to the interior. And in the second year it reached Byzantium in the middle of spring, where it happened that I was staying at that time.

...

And they were taken in the following manner. They had a sudden fever, some when just roused from sleep, others while walking about, and others while otherwise engaged, without any regard to what they were doing. And the body shewed no change from its previous colour, nor was it hot as might be expected when attacked by a fever, nor indeed did any inflammation set in, but the fever was of such a languid sort from its commencement and up till evening that neither to the sick themselves nor to a physician who touched them would it afford any suspicion of danger. It was natural, therefore, that not one of those who had contracted the disease expected to die from it. But on the same day in some cases, in others on the following day, and in the rest not many days

later, a bubonic swelling developed; and this took place not only in the particular part of the body which is called "bubon," that is, below the abdomen, but also inside the armpit, and in some cases also beside the ears, and at different points on the thighs.

Up to this point, then, everything went in about the same way with all who had taken the disease. But from then on very marked differences developed; and I am unable to say whether the cause of this diversity of symptoms was to be found in the difference in bodies, or in the fact that it followed the wish of Him who brought the disease into the world. For there ensued with some a deep coma, with others a violent delirium, and in either case they suffered the characteristic symptoms of the disease. For those who were under the spell of the coma forgot all those who were familiar to them and seemed to be sleeping constantly. And if anyone cared for them, they would eat without waking, but some also were neglected, and these would die directly through lack of sustenance. But those who were seized with delirium suffered from insomnia and were victims of a distorted imagination; for they suspected that men were coming upon them to destroy them, and they would become excited and rush off in flight, crying out at the top of their voices. And those who were attending them were in a state of constant exhaustion and had a most difficult time of it throughout. For this reason everybody pitied them no less than the sufferers, not because they were threatened by the pestilence in going near it (for neither physicians nor other persons were found to contract this malady through contact with the sick or with the dead, for many who were constantly engaged either in burying or in attending those in no way connected with them held out in the performance of this service beyond all expectation, while with many others the disease came on without warning and they died straightway); but they pitied them because of the great hardships which they were undergoing. For when the patients fell from their beds and lay rolling upon the floor, they kept patting them back in place, and when they were struggling to rush headlong out of their houses, they would force them back by shoving and pulling against them. And when water chanced to be near, they wished to fall into it, not so much because of a desire for drink (for the most of them rushed into the sea), but the cause was to be found chiefly in the diseased state of their minds. They had also great difficulty in the matter of eating, for they could not easily take food. And many perished through lack of any man to care for them, for they were either overcome by hunger, or threw themselves down from a height. And in those cases where neither coma nor delirium came on, the bubonic swelling became mortified and the sufferer, no longer able to endure the pain, died. And one would suppose that in all cases the same thing would have been true, but since they were not at all in their senses, some were quite unable to feel the pain; for owing to the troubled condition of their minds they lost all sense of feeling.

Now some of the physicians who were at a loss because the symptoms were not understood, supposing that the disease centred in the bubonic swellings, decided to investigate the bodies of the dead. And upon opening some of the swellings, they found a strange sort of carbuncle that had grown inside them. Death came in some cases immediately, in others after many days; and with some the body broke out with black pustules about as large as a lentil and these did not survive even one day, but all succumbed immediately. With many also a vomiting of blood ensued without visible cause and straightway brought death. Moreover I am able to declare this, that the most illustrious physicians predicted that many would die, who unexpectedly escaped entirely from suffering shortly afterwards, and that they declared that many



St. Sebastian was a Roman military officer martyred about AD 300 by being shot full of arrows and then clubbed to death. He was prayed to for protection against the plague.

"Saint Sebastian Interceding for the Plague Stricken" by Josse Lieferinxe is in the [Public Domain](#)

would be saved, who were destined to be carried off almost immediately. So it was that in this disease there was no cause which came within the province of human reasoning; for in all cases the issue tended to be something unaccountable. For example, while some were helped by bathing, others were harmed in no less degree. And of those who received no care many died, but others, contrary to reason, were saved. And again, methods of treatment shewed different results with different patients. Indeed the whole matter may be stated thus, that no device was discovered by man to save himself, so that either by taking precautions he should not suffer, or that when the malady had assailed him he should get the better of it; but suffering came without warning and recovery was due to no external cause.

....

XXIII

Now the disease in Byzantium ran a course of four months, and its greatest virulence lasted about three. And at first the deaths were a little more than the normal, then the mortality rose still higher, and afterwards the tale of dead reached five thousand each day, and again it even came to ten thousand and still more than that. Now in the beginning each man attended to the burial of the dead of his own house, and these they threw even into the tombs of others, either escaping detection or using violence; but afterwards confusion and disorder everywhere became complete. For slaves remained destitute of masters, and men who in former times were very prosperous were deprived of the service of their domestics who were either sick or dead, and many houses became completely destitute of human inhabitants. For this reason it came about that some of the notable men of the city because of the universal destitution remained unburied for many days.



Roman Emperor Justinian (reigned 527-565) and members of his court are depicted in this famous mosaic, at Basilica of San Vitale in Ravenna, Italy. "[Ravenna - Justinian Mosaic at San Vitale](#)" by [Roger W](#) is licensed under [CC BY-SA 2.0](#)

And it fell to the lot of the emperor, as was natural, to make provision for the trouble. He therefore detailed soldiers from the palace and distributed money, commanding Theodorus to take charge of this work; this man held the position of announcer of imperial messages, always announcing to the emperor the petitions of his clients, and declaring to them in turn whatever his wish was. In the Latin tongue the Romans designate this office by the term "referendarius." So those who had not as yet fallen into complete destitution in their domestic affairs attended individually to the burial of those connected with them. But Theodorus, by giving out the emperor's money and by making further expenditures from his own purse, kept burying the bodies which were not cared for.

....

At that time all the customary rites of burial were overlooked. For the dead were not carried out escorted by a procession in the customary manner, nor were the usual chants sung over them, but it was sufficient if one carried on his shoulders the body of one of the dead to the parts of the city which bordered on the sea and flung him down; and there the corpses would be thrown upon skiffs in a heap, to be conveyed wherever it might chance. At that time, too, those of the population who had formerly been members of the factions laid aside their mutual enmity and in common they attended to the burial rites of the dead, and they carried with their own hands the bodies of those who were no connections of theirs and buried them. Nay, more, those who in times past used to take delight in devoting themselves to pursuits both shameful and base, shook off the unrighteousness of their daily lives and practised the duties of religion with diligence, not so much because they had learned wisdom at last nor because they had become all of a sudden lovers of virtue, as it were—for when qualities have become fixed in men by nature or by the training of a long period of time, it is impossible for them to lay them aside thus lightly, except, indeed, some divine influence for good has breathed upon

them—but then all, so to speak, being thoroughly terrified by the things which were happening, and supposing that they would die immediately, did, as was natural, learn respectability for a season by sheer necessity. Therefore as soon as they were rid of the disease and were saved, and already supposed that they were in security, since the curse had moved on to other peoples, then they turned sharply about and reverted once more to their baseness of heart, and now, more than before, they make a display of the inconsistency of their conduct, altogether surpassing themselves in villainy and in lawlessness of every sort. For one could insist emphatically without falsehood that this disease, whether by chance or by some providence, chose out with exactitude the worst men and let them go free. But these things were displayed to the world in later times.

During that time it seemed no easy thing to see any man in the streets of Byzantium, but all who had the good fortune to be in health were sitting in their houses, either attending the sick or mourning the dead. And if one did succeed in meeting a man going out, he was carrying one of the dead. And work of every description ceased, and all the trades were abandoned by the artisans, and all other work as well, such as each had in hand. Indeed in a city which was simply abounding in all good things starvation almost absolute was running riot. Certainly it seemed a difficult and very notable thing to have a sufficiency of bread or of anything else; so that with some of the sick it appeared that the end of life came about sooner than it should have come by reason of the lack of the necessities of life. And, to put all in a word, it was not possible to see a single man in Byzantium clad in the chlamys, and especially when the emperor became ill (for he too had a swelling of the groin), but in a city which held dominion over the whole Roman empire every man was wearing clothes befitting private station and remaining quietly at home. Such was the course of the pestilence in the Roman empire at large as well as in Byzantium. And it fell also upon the land of the Persians and visited all the other barbarians besides.

Glossary:

- Aegypt, Aegyptians - an archaic spelling of Egypt and Egyptians, respectively.
- Byzantium - the capital of the Byzantine Empire in Anatolia; modern day Istanbul.
- carbuncle - a large cluster of boils often found with bacterial infections.
- chlamys - a large cloak covering worn by high officials and emperors in the Byzantine Empire.
- languid - being lazy or sluggish
- lentil - a legume seed about a quarter of an inch long.
- Pelusium - a port city in Egypt along the easternmost Nile Delta.
- scourges - sources of suffering and destruction often as a form of punishment.

Questions:

1. In what ways was this disease and its impact similar to the one described by Thucydides?
2. What economic impact did this plague have on Byzantium? Compare and contrast that with the economic impact of modern epidemics like Covid-19.
3. Procopius takes time in this excerpt to discuss what was done with the bodies of those who died from the Plague. Why do you think that is? Why was that issue important enough to warrant an entire page in this excerpt? What parallels can be drawn between what Procopius wrote about and what we're witnessing today?

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1.3: “All human wisdom and foresight were vain-” Foreword to The Decameron

historical comparisons. For instance, though there are some similarities between the Covid-19 outbreak and the bubonic plague of the fourteenth century, there are also crucial differences in the contexts in which those diseases spread. Studying those differences helps us understand what happened in the 1300s and why, as well as what’s happening now and why. You’ll find that in addition to questions highlighting parallels, there are also questions that aim to uncover differences between the events of the past and those of the present.

We sincerely hope you find this resource helpful, and are excited to see the creative ways faculty will put this collection to good use.

Ryan Johnson

St. Clair County Community College

2.

3.

“All human wisdom and foresight were vain:” Foreword to The Decameron

By Giovanni Boccaccio

Introduction:

The Black Death is the name given to the plague that struck Europe in 1347 and lasted until 1352. The Plague reached Europe via trade routes, both land and sea, to the east, where the disease had been ravaging China since the early 1300s. Normally ascribed to bubonic plague (named after the buboes, or swellings that developed on the body), the Plague also took the pneumonic form and could be spread from person to person via coughing and sneezing, as well as the septicemic form when it entered the blood.

The Black Death was widespread, affecting people across Europe. People of all ages and social classes were killed by the disease, which wiped out as much as 40% of Europe’s total population. The Plague also devastated the Middle East and Asia, killing the populations of entire villages and towns. Even though the Black Death was the worst instance of plague, the disease would return to Europe, usually once every generation or so, for centuries.

The following excerpt comes from Italian writer Giovanni Boccaccio, who lived in Italy during the plague years. The work excerpted here is from Boccaccio’s *Decameron*, a fictional tale of ten friends who take up residence in an abandoned church in the country outside the city of Florence. They’ve tried to isolate themselves from the disease and are passing the time telling stories. In the introduction to the *Decameron*, presented here, the narrator discusses the onset of the Plague on the city of Florence, as well as the many different reactions to the spread of the disease.

In the year 1348 after the fruitful incarnation of the Son of God, that most beautiful of Italian cities, noble Florence, was attacked by deadly plague. It started in the East either through the influence of the heavenly bodies or because God’s just anger with our wicked deeds sent it as a punishment to mortal men; and in a few years killed an innumerable quantity of people. Ceaselessly passing from place to place, it extended its miserable length over the West. Against this plague all human wisdom and foresight were vain. Orders had been given to cleanse the city of filth, the entry of any sick person was forbidden, much advice was given for keeping healthy; at the same time humble supplications were made to God by pious persons in processions and otherwise. And yet, in the beginning of the spring of the year mentioned, its horrible results began to appear, and in a miraculous manner. The symptoms were not the same as in the East, where a gush of blood from the nose was the plain sign of inevitable death; but it began both in men and women with certain swellings in the groin or under the armpit. They grew to the size of a small apple or an egg, more or less, and were vulgarly called tumours. In a short space of time these tumours spread from the two parts named all over the body. Soon after this the symptoms changed and black or purple spots appeared on the arms or thighs or any other part of the body, sometimes a few large ones, sometimes many little ones. These spots were a certain sign of death, just as the original tumour had been and still remained.

No doctor’s advice, no medicine could overcome or alleviate this disease. An enormous number of ignorant men and women set up as doctors in addition to those who were trained. Either the disease was such that no treatment was possible or the doctors were so ignorant that they did not know what caused it, and consequently could not administer the proper remedy. In any case very few

recovered; most people died within about three days of the appearance of the tumours described above, most of them without any fever or other symptoms.

The violence of this disease was such that the sick communicate it to the healthy who came near them, just as a fire catches anything dry or oily near it. And it even went further. To speak to or go near the sick brought infection and a common death to the living; and moreover, to touch the clothes or anything else the sick had touched or worn gave the disease to the person touching.

....

Some thought that moderate living and the avoidance of all superfluity would preserve them from the epidemic. They formed small communities, living entirely separate from everybody else. They shut themselves up in houses where there were no sick, eating the finest food and drinking the best wine very temperately, avoiding all excess, allowing no news or discussion of death and sickness, and passing the time in music and suchlike pleasures. Others thought just the opposite. They thought the sure cure for the plague was to drink and be merry, to go about singing and amusing themselves, satisfying every appetite they could, laughing and jesting at what happened. They put their words into practice, spent day and night going from tavern to tavern, drinking immoderately, or went into other people's houses, doing only those things which pleased them. This they could easily do because everyone felt doomed and had abandoned his property, so that most houses became common property and any stranger who went in made use of them as if he had owned them. And with all this bestial behaviour, they avoided the sick as much as possible.

In this suffering and misery of our city, the authority of human and divine laws almost disappeared, for, like other men, the ministers and the executors of the laws were all dead or sick or shut up with their families, so that no duties were carried out. Every man was therefore able to do as he pleased.



Detail from a 19th Century illustration of Boccaccio's Decameron showing the ten young people who traveled together to escape the plague outbreak in Florence. "[Decameron](#)" is in the [Public Domain](#)

Many others adopted a course of life midway between the two just described. They did not restrict their victuals so much as the former, nor allow themselves to be drunken and dissolute like the latter, but satisfied their appetites moderately. They did not shut themselves up, but went about, carrying flowers or scented herbs or perfumes in their hands, in the belief that it was an excellent

thing to comfort the brain with such odours; for the whole air was infected with the smell of dead bodies, of sick persons and medicines.

Others again held a still more cruel opinion, which they thought would keep them safe. They said that the only medicine against the plague-stricken was to go right away from them. Men and women, convinced of this and caring about nothing but themselves, abandoned their own city, their own houses, their dwellings, their relatives, their property, and went abroad or at least to the country round Florence, as if God's wrath in punishing men's wickedness with this plague would not follow them but strike only those who remained within the walls of the city, or as if they thought nobody in the city would remain alive and that its last hour had come.

Not everyone who adopted any of these various opinions died, nor did all escape. Some when they were still healthy had set the example of avoiding the sick, and, falling ill themselves, died untended.

One citizen avoided another, hardly any neighbour troubled about others, relatives never or hardly ever visited each other. Moreover, such terror was struck into the hearts of men and women by this calamity, that brother abandoned brother, and the uncle his nephew, and the sister her brother, and very often the wife her husband. What is even worse and nearly incredible is that fathers and mothers refused to see and tend their children, as if they had not been theirs.

Thus, a multitude of sick men and women were left without any care except from the charity of friends (but these were few), or the greed of servants, though not many of these could be had even for high wages. Moreover, most of them were coarse-minded men and women, who did little more than bring the sick what they asked for or watch over them when they were dying. And very often these servants lost their lives and their earnings. Since the sick were thus abandoned by neighbours, relatives and friends, while servants were scarce, a habit sprang up which had never been heard of before. Beautiful and noble women, when they fell sick, did not scruple to take a young or old man-servant, whoever he might be, and with no sort of shame, expose every part of their bodies to these men as if they had been women, for they were compelled by the necessity of their sickness to do so. This, perhaps, was a cause of looser morals in those women who survived.

In this way many people died who might have been saved if they had been looked after. Owing to the lack of attendants for the sick and the violence of the plague, such a multitude of people in the city died day and night that it was stupefying to hear of, let alone to see. From sheer necessity, then, several ancient customs were quite altered among the survivors.

...

Few were they whose bodies were accompanied to church by more than ten or a dozen neighbours. Nor were these grave and honourable citizens but grave-diggers from the lowest of the people who got themselves called sextons, and performed the task for money. They took up the bier and hurried it off, not to the church chosen by the deceased but to the church nearest, preceded by four or six of the clergy with few candles and often none at all. With the aid of the grave-diggers, the clergy huddled the bodies away in any grave they could find, without giving themselves the trouble of a long or solemn burial service.

The plight of the lower and most of the middle classes was even more pitiful to behold. Most of them remained in their houses, either through poverty or in hopes of safety, and fell sick by thousands. Since they received no care and attention, almost all of them died. Many ended their lives in the streets both at night and during the day; and many others who died in their houses were only known to be dead because the neighbours smelled their decaying bodies. Dead bodies filled every corner. Most of them were treated in the same manner by the survivors, who were more concerned to get rid of their rotting bodies than moved by charity towards the dead. With the aid of porters, if they could get them, they carried the bodies out of the houses and laid them at the doors, where every morning quantities of the dead might be seen. They then were laid on biers or, as these were often lacking, on tables.

Often a single bier carried two or three bodies, and it happened frequently that a husband and wife, two or three brothers, or father and son were taken off on the same bier. It frequently happened that two priests, each carrying a cross, would go out followed by three or four biers carried by porters; and where the priests thought there was one person to bury, there would be six or eight, and often, even more. Nor were these dead honoured by tears and lighted candles and mourners, for things had reached such a pass that people cared no more for dead men than we care for dead goats. . . .



The burial of the victims of the plague in Tournai. Detail of a miniature from "The Chronicles of Gilles Li Muisis" (1272-1352), abbot of the monastery of St. Martin of the Righteous.

"Burying Plague Victims of Tournai" is in the [Public Domain](#)

Such was the multitude of corpses brought to the churches every day and almost every hour that there was not enough consecrated ground to give them burial, especially since they wanted to bury each person in the family grave, according to the old custom. Although the cemeteries were full they were forced to dig huge trenches, where they buried the bodies by hundreds. Here they stowed them away like bales in the hold of a ship and covered them with a little earth, until the whole trench was full.

Not to pry any further into all the details of the miseries which afflicted our city, I shall add that the surrounding country was spared nothing of what befell Florence. The villages on a smaller scale were like the city; in the fields and isolated farms the poor wretched peasants and their families were without doctors and any assistance, and perished in the highways, in their fields and houses, night and day, more like beasts than men. Just as the townsmen became dissolute and indifferent to their work and property, so the peasants, when they saw that death was upon them, entirely neglected the future fruits of their past labours both from the earth and from cattle, and thought only of enjoying what they had. Thus it happened that cows, asses, sheep, goats, pigs, fowls and even dogs, those faithful companions of man, left the farms and wandered at their will through the fields, where the wheat crops stood abandoned, unreaped and ungarnered. Many of these animals seemed endowed with reason, for, after they had pastured all day, they returned to the farms for the night of their own free will, without being driven.

Returning from the country to the city, it may be said that such was the cruelty of Heaven, and perhaps in part of men, that between March and July more than one hundred thousand persons died within the walls of Florence, what between the violence of the plague and the abandonment in which the sick were left by the cowardice of the healthy. And before the plague it was not thought that the whole city held so many people.

Oh, what great palaces, how many fair houses and noble dwellings, once filled with attendants and nobles and ladies, were emptied to the meanest servant! How many famous names and vast possessions and renowned estates were left without an heir! How many gallant men and fair ladies and handsome youths, whom Galen, Hippocrates and Aesculapius themselves would have said were in perfect health, at noon dined with their relatives and friends, and at night supped with their ancestors in the next world!

Glossary:

- Aesclepius - a Greek god of healing and medicine who may have been a real person that achieved a mythical reputation.
 - bier - a cart or stretcher that is used to transport corpses.
 - Hippocrates - an ancient Greek physician, often called the Father of Medicine, who is credited with creating the Hippocratic Oath that American medicine still uses.
 - Galen - an ancient Roman physician, surgeon, and medical researcher, particularly in the field of anatomy, physiology, and pharmacology.
 - stupefying - having a dazzling or amazing quality.
 - superfluidity - being in excess of what is needed or luxurious.
 - victuals - food or supplies.
-

Questions:

1. How did the people of Florence react to the onset of the Black Death in their city? How are those reactions similar to, and different from, the reactions of contemporary people to outbreaks like Covid-19?
 2. What role did economic status play in how the people of Florence responded to the Plague?
 3. Compare what Boccaccio relates here to what Thucydides and Procopius wrote about in the first two documents.
-

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1.4: A Journal of the Plague Year- Bubonic Plague in London, 1665

A Journal of the Plague Year: Bubonic Plague in London, 1665

By Daniel Defoe

Introduction:

Daniel Defoe (c. 1660 – 1731) was an English writer, journalist, and trader. He is best known for his 1719 novel, Robinson Crusoe . In 1722, Defoe published A Journal of the Plague Year, a detailed account of a man living through the Great Plague of London in the year 1665. Defoe was only five years old in 1665 when the Great Plague took place, and the book itself was published under the initials H. F. and is probably based on the journals of Defoe's uncle, Henry Foe, who, like 'H. F.', was a saddler who lived in the Whitechapel district of East London.

London in 1665 was a walled city with very poor sanitary conditions which created an environment ideal for the rats and fleas that carried bubonic plague. In seven months, almost one quarter of London's population (one out of every four Londoners) died from the plague. At its worst, in September of 1665, the plague killed 7,165 people in one week. Defoe's descriptions of life during that year are vivid and detailed. Even though he was not an actual eyewitness to the plague year, his account is a valuable resource in understanding the social dynamics and human costs of the event.

Again, the public showed that they would bear their share in these things; the very court, which was then gay and luxurious, put on a face of just concern for the public

danger. All the plays and interludes, which, after the manner of the French court, had been set up and began to increase among us, were forbidden to act; the gaming- tables, public dancing rooms, and music houses, which multiplied and began to debauch the manners of the people, were shut up and suppressed; and the jack-puddings, merry-andrews, puppet-shows, rope-dancers, and such-like doings, which had bewitched the common people, shut their shops, finding indeed no trade, for the minds of the people were agitated with other things, and a kind of sadness and horror at these things sat upon the countenances even of the common people; death was before their eyes, and everybody began to think of their graves,' not of mirth and diversions.

But even these wholesome reflections, which, rightly managed, would have most happily led the people to fall upon their knees, make confession of their sins, and look up to their merciful Saviour for pardon, imploring his compassion on them in such a time of their distress, by which we might have been as a second Nineveh, had a quite contrary extreme in the common people: who, ignorant and stupid in their reflections, as they were brutishly wicked and thoughtless before, were now led by their fright to extremes of folly; and, as I said before, that they ran to conjurers and witches and all sorts of deceivers, to know what should become of them, who fed their fears and kept them always alarmed and awake, on purpose to delude them and pick their pockets, so they were as mad upon their running after quacks and



"The black death in London" by Unknown is in the [Public Domain](#)

mountebanks and every practising old woman for medicines and remedies, storing themselves with such multitudes of pills, potions, and preservatives, as they were called, that they not only spent their money but poisoned themselves beforehand for fear of the poison of the infection, and prepared their bodies for the plague instead of pressing them against it. On the other hand, it was incredible, and scarce to be imagined, how the posts of houses and corners of streets were plastered over with doctors' bills, and papers of ignorant fellows quacking and tampering in physic, and inviting people to come to them for remedies, which was generally set off with such flourishes as these: "INFALLIBLE preventative pills against the plague." "NEVER-FAILING preservatives against the infection." "SOVEREIGN cordials against the corruption of air." "EXACT regulations for the conduct of the body in case of infection." "Anti Pestilential pills." "INCOMPARABLE drink against the plague, never found out before." "An UNIVERSAL remedy for the plague." "The ONLY TRUE plague-water." "The ROYAL ANTIDOTE against all kinds of infection" and such a number more that I cannot reckon up, and, if I could, would fill a book of themselves to set them down.

....

I had in my family only an ancient woman, that managed the house, a maid-servant, two apprentices, and myself, and the plague beginning to increase about us, I had

many sad thoughts about what course I should take, and how I should act; the many dismal objects which happened everywhere, as I went about the streets, had filled

my mind with a great deal of horror, for fear of the distemper itself, which was, indeed, very horrible in itself, and in some more than others; the swellings, which were generally in the neck or groin, when they grew hard, and would not break, grew so painful that it was equal to the most exquisite torture; and some, not able to bear the torment, threw themselves out at windows, or shot themselves, or otherwise made themselves away, and I saw several dismal objects of that kind: others, unable to contain themselves, vented their pain by incessant roarings, and such loud and lamentable cries were to be heard, as we walked along the streets, that would pierce the very heart to think of, especially when it was to be considered that

the same dreadful scourge might be expected every moment to seize upon ourselves.

I cannot say but that now I began to faint in my resolutions; my heart failed me very much, and sorely I repented of my rashness, when I had been out, and met with

such terrible things as these I have talked of; I say, I repented my rashness in venturing to abide in town, and I wished, often, that I had not taken upon me to stay, but had gone away with my brother and his family.

Terrified by those frightful objects, I would retire home sometimes, and resolve to go out no more, and perhaps I would keep those resolutions for three or four days, which time I spent in the most serious thankfulness for my preservation, and the preservation of my family, and the constant confession of my sins, giving myself up to God every day, and applying to him with fasting and humiliation and meditation. Such intervals as I had, I employed in reading books, and in writing down my memorandums of what occurred to me every day, and out of which, afterwards, I took most of this work, as it relates to my observations without doors . . .

I had a very good friend, a physician, whose name was Heath, whom I frequently visited during this dismal time, and to whose advice I was very much obliged for many things which he directed me to take by way of preventing the infection when I went out, as he found I frequently did, and to hold in my mouth, when I was in the streets; he also came very often to see me, and as he was a good Christian, as well as a good physician, his agreeable conversation was a very great support to me, in the worst of this terrible time.

It was now the beginning of August, and the plague grew very violent and terrible in the place where I lived, and Dr. Heath, coming to visit me and finding that I ventured so often out in the streets, earnestly persuaded me to lock myself up, and my family, and not to suffer any of us to go out of doors; to keep all our windows fast, shutters and curtains close, and never to open them, but first to make a very strong smoke in the room, where the window or door was to be opened, with rosin and pitch, brimstone and gunpowder, and the like, and we did this for some time, but as I had not laid in a store of provision for such a retreat, it was impossible that we could keep within doors entirely; however, I attempted, though it was so very late, to do something towards it; and first, as I had convenience both for brewing and baking, I went and bought two sacks of meal, and for several weeks, having an oven, we baked all our own bread; also I bought malt, and brewed as much beer as all the casks I had would hold, and which seemed enough to serve my house for five or six

weeks; also, I laid in a quantity of salt butter and Cheshire cheese; but I had no flesh meat, and the plague raged so violently among the butchers and slaughter-

houses, on the other side of our street, where they are known to dwell in great numbers, that it was not advisable so much as to go over the street among them.

And here I must observe again that this necessity of going out of our houses to buy provisions, was in a great measure the ruin of the whole city, for the people caught

the distemper, on these occasions, one of another, and even the provisions themselves were often tainted, at least I have great reason to believe so; and, therefore, I cannot say with satisfaction, what I know is repeated with great

assurance, that the market people, and such as brought provisions to town, were never infected. I am certain the butchers of Whitechapel, where the greatest part of the flesh meat was killed, were dreadfully visited, and that at last to such a degree that few of their shops were kept open, and those that remained of them killed their meat at Mile End, and that way, and brought it to market upon horses.

However, the poor people could not lay up provisions, and there was a necessity that they must go to market to buy, and others to send servants, or their children; and,

as this was a necessity which renewed itself daily, it brought abundance of unsound people to the markets, and a great many that went thither sound, brought death home with them.

It is true, people used all possible precaution ; when any one bought a joint of meat in the market, they would not take it out of the butcher's hand, but took it off the hooks themselves. On the other hand, the butcher would not touch the money, but have it put into a pot full of vinegar, which he kept for that purpose. The buyer carried always small money to make up any odd sum, that they might take no change. They carried bottles for scents and perfumes in their hands, and all the means that could be used were employed; but then the poor could not do even these things, and they went at all hazards.

. . . .

But now the fury of the distemper increased to such a degree, that even the markets were but very thinly furnished with provisions, or frequented with buyers, compared to what they were before; and the lord mayor caused the country people who brought provisions, to be stopped in the streets leading into the town, and to sit down there with their goods, where they sold what they brought, and went immediately away; and this encouraged the country people greatly to do so, for they sold their provisions at the very entrances into the town, and even in the fields; us, particularly, in the fields beyond Whitechapel, in Spitalfields.

....

As for my little family, having thus, as I have said, laid in a store of bread, butter, cheese, and beer, I took my friend and physician's advice,' and locked myself up, and my family, and resolved to suffer the hardship of living a few months without flesh meat, rather than to purchase it at the hazard of our lives.

....

At the beginning of the plague, when there was now no more hope but that the whole city would be visited; when, as I have said, all that had friends or estates in the country retired with their families, and when, indeed, one would have thought the very city itself was running out of the gates, and that there would be nobody left behind, you may be sure, from that hour, all trade except such as related to immediate subsistence, was, as it were, at a full stop.

This is so striking a circumstance and contains in it so much of the real condition of the people, that I think I cannot be too particular in it; and, therefore, I descend to the several arrangements or classes of people who fell into immediate

distress upon this occasion. For example,

1. All master workmen in manufactures; especially such as belonged to ornament, and the less necessary parts of the people's dress, clothes, and furniture for houses; such as ribband weavers and other weavers, gold and silver lace makers, and gold and silver wire drawers, seamstresses, milliners, shoemakers, hat-makers, and glove-makers; also upholsterers, joiners, cabinet-makers, looking-glass-makers, and innumerable trades which depend upon such as these. I say the master workmen in such stopped their work, dismissed their journeymen and workmen, and all their dependents.

The Diseases and Casualties this Week.

A Bortive	5
Aged	43
Ague	2
Apoplexie	1
Bleeding	2
Burnt in his Bed by a Candle at St. Giles Cripplegate	1
Canker	1
Childbed	42
Chrifomes	18
Consumption	134
Convulſion	64
Cough	2
Dropſie	33
Feaver	309
Flox and Small-pox	5
Frighted	3
Gowt	1
Grief	3
Gripping in the Guts	51
Jaundies	5

Impoſthume	11
Infants	16
Killed by a fall from the Bel- frey at Alhallows the Great	1
Kingfevil	2
Leibargy	1
Palſie	1
Plague	7165
Rickets	17
Riſing of the Lights	11
Scowring	5
Scurvy	2
Spleen	1
Spotted Feaver	101
Stillborn	17
Stone	2
Stopping of the ſtomach	9
Strangury	1
Suddenly	1
Surfeit	49
Teeth	121
Thruth	5
Timpany	1
Tuſſick	11
Vomiting	3
Winde	3
Wormes	15

Chriſtined { Males — 95 }
 { Females — 81 }
 { In all — 176 }

Buried { Males — 4095 }
 { Females — 4202 }
 { In all — 8297 }
 Plague — 7165

Increased in the Burials this Week

607

Parishes clear of the Plague

4

Parishes Infected

126

*The Aſſize of Bread ſet forth by Order of the Lord Mayor and Courts of Aldermen,
 A penny Wheaten Loaf to contain Nine Ounces and a half, and three
 half-penny White Loaves the like weight.*

Bill of mortality for the week of 19th–26th September 1665, which saw the highest death toll from plague.

"The diseases and casualties of this week" by [Public Domain Review](#) is in the [Public Domain](#)

2. As merchandising was at a full stop (for very few ships ventured to come up the river, and none at all went out), so all the extraordinary officers of the customs, like-

wise the watermen, cartmen, porters, and all the poor whose labour depended upon the merchants, were at once dismissed, and put out of business.

3. All the tradesmen usually employed in building or repairing of houses were at a full stop, for the people were far from wanting to build houses, when so many thousand

houses were at once stript of their inhabitants; so that [in this particular set of circumstances] turned out all the ordinary workmen of that kind of business, such as bricklayers, masons, carpenters, joiners, plasterers, painters, glaziers, smiths, plumbers, and all the labourers depending on such.

4. As navigation was at a stop, our ships neither coming in or going out as before, so the seamen were all out of employment, and many of them in the last and lowest degree of distress; and with the seamen were all the several tradesmen and workmen belonging to and depending upon the building and fitting out of ships; such as ship-carpenters, calkers, rope-makers, dry coopers, sail-makers, anchor-smiths and other smiths; block-makers, carvers, gunsmiths, ship-chandlers, ship-carvers, and the like. The masters of those, perhaps, might live upon their substance, but the traders were universally at a stop, and consequently all their workmen discharged. Add to these, that the river was in a manner without boats, and all or most part of the watermen, lightermen, boat-builders, and lighter builders, in like manner idle, and laid by.

5. All families retrenched their living as much as possible, as well those that fled as those that stayed; so that an innumerable multitude of footmen, serving men, shop-

keepers, journeymen, merchants' book-keepers, and such sort of people, and especially poor maid-servants, were turned off, and left friendless and helpless without employment and without habitation; and this was really a dismal article.

I might be more particular as to this part, but it may suffice to mention, in general, all trades being stopped, employment ceased, the labour, and, by that, the bread of the

poor, were cut off; and at first, indeed, the cries of the poor were most lamentable to hear; though, by the distribution of charity, their misery that way was gently abated.

Many, indeed, fled into the country; but thousands of them having stayed in London, till nothing but desperation sent them away, death overtook them on the road, and

they served for no better than the messengers of death; indeed, others carrying the infection along with them, spread it very unhappily into the remotest parts of the

kingdom.

The women and servants that were turned off from their places were employed as nurses to tend the sick in all places; and this took off a very great number of them.

And which though a melancholy article in itself, yet was a deliverance in its kind, namely, the plague, which raged in a dreadful manner from the middle of August to

the middle of October, carried off in that time thirty or forty thousand of these very people, which, had they been left, would certainly have been an insufferable burden, by their poverty; that is to say, the whole city could not have supported the expense of them, or have provided food for them; and they would, in time, have been even driven to the necessity of plundering either the city itself, or the country adjacent, to have subsisted themselves, which would, first or last, have put the whole nation, as well as the city, into the utmost terror and confusion.



"Great plague of London-1665" by Unknown is in the [Public Domain](#)

It was observable then that this calamity of the people made them very humble; for now, for about nine weeks together, there died near a thousand a day, one day with

another; even by the account of the weekly bills, which yet, I have reason to be assured, never gave a full account by many thousands; the confusion being such, and the carts working in the dark when they carried the dead, that in some places no account at all was kept, but they worked on; the clerks and sextons not attending for weeks together, and not knowing what number they carried.

....

Now, when I say that the parish officers did not give in a full account, or were not to be depended upon for their account, let any one but consider how men could be exact in such a time of dreadful distress, and when many of them were taken sick themselves, and perhaps died in the very time when their accounts were to be given in; I mean the parish-clerks, besides inferior officers; for though these poor men ventured at all hazards, yet they were far from being exempt from the common calamity; especially if it be true that the parish of Stepney had, within the year, 116 sextons, grave-diggers, and their assistants; that is to say, bearers, bell-men, and drivers of carts, for carrying off the dead bodies.

Indeed, the work was not of such a nature as to allow them leisure to take an exact tale of the dead bodies, which were all huddled together, in the dark, into a pit; which pit, or trench, no man could come nigh but at the utmost peril. I have observed often, that in the parishes of. Aidgate, Cripplegate, Whitechapel, and Stepney, there were

five, six, seven, and eight hundred in a week in the bills; whereas, if we may believe the opinion of those that lived in the city all the time, as well as I, there died sometimes two thousand a week in those parishes; and I saw it under the hand of one that made as

strict an examination as he could, that there really died a hundred thousand people of the plague in it that one year; whereas, in the bills, the article of the plague was but 68,590.

....

This infecting and being infected, without so much as its being known to either person, is evident from two sorts of cases, which frequently happened at that time; and there is hardly anybody living, who was in London during the infection, but must have known several of the cases of both sorts.

1. Fathers and mothers have gone about as if they had been well, and have believed themselves to be so, till they have insensibly infected and been the destruction of their whole families; which they would have been far from doing, if they had had the least apprehensions of their being unsound and dangerous themselves. A family, whose story I have heard, was thus infected by the father, and the distemper began to appear upon some of them even before he found it upon himself; but searching more narrowly, it appeared he had been infected some time, and as soon as he found that his family had been poisoned by himself, he went distracted, and would have laid violent hands upon himself, but was kept from that by those who looked

to him, and in a few days he died.

2. The other particular is, that many people having been well to the best of their own judgment, or by the best observation which they could make of themselves for several days, and only finding a decay of appetite, or a light sickness upon their stomachs; nay, some whose appetite has been strong, and even craving, and only a light pain in their heads, have sent for physicians to know what ailed them, and have been found, to their great surprise, at the brink of death, the tokens upon them, or the plague grown up to an incurable height.

It was very sad to reflect, how such a person as this last mentioned above, had been a walking destroyer, perhaps for a week or fortnight before that; how he had ruined

those that he would have hazarded his life to save; and had been breathing death upon them, even perhaps in his tender kissing and embracings of his own children. Yet thus certainly it was, and often has been, and I could give many particular cases where it has been so. If, then, the blow is thus insensibly striking; if the arrow flies thus unseen and cannot be discovered; to what purpose are all the schemes for shutting up or removing the sick people? Those schemes cannot take place but upon those that appear to be sick, or to be infected; whereas there are among them, at the same time, thousands of people who seem to be well, but are all that while carrying death with them into all companies which they come into.

This frequently puzzled our physicians, and especially the apothecaries and surgeons, who knew not how to discover the sick from the sound. They all allowed that it was really so; that many people had the plague in their very blood, and preying upon their spirits, and were in themselves but walking putrefied carcasses, whose breath was infectious, and their sweat poison, and yet were as well to look on as other people, and even knew it not themselves; I say, they all allowed that it was really true in fact, but they knew not how to propose a discovery.

Glossary:

- Court - The group that attends to and lives with the royal family, including bodyguards, relatives, amongst others.
- Dry coopers - Barrel-makers, specifically those who make barrels for dry goods such as grains, fruits, or vegetables.
- Jack-pudding - A foolish and bumbling comedic archetype of stage and street performers.
- Journeymen - A trade worker that serves under a master and often is paid daily with a fairly low skill level.
- Melancholy - A sadness or depression; something that evokes sad feelings.
- Merry-andrews - A performer who acts as a clown, often in service to another performer.
- Mile End - At the time of this document, it was a hamlet one mile from Aldgate, which marked the edge of London, which was a significant trading hub. In modern times, it's a district of the Greater London Area.
- Mountebanks - A person who sells often fake medicines and treatments, akin to a snake-oil salesman.
- Nineveh - The historical capital of the Assyrian Empire which in Biblical tradition was utterly obliterated by God's wrath for the Assyrian's pride.
- Physic - An archaic term for the healing practice; medicine.
- Rope-dancers - A tightrope walker or similar acrobat.
- Rosin and pitch, brimstone and gunpowder - Rosin and pitch are solid plant resins, brimstone is a term for sulphur, and gunpowder is an explosive and fuel. When burned all of these produce heavy smoke and strong smells which would block the miasma: bad odors that doctors believed caused diseases.

- Sextons - A church official that tended to the church building and it's graveyard.
 - Spitalfields - A small field just outside London with sparse housing.
 - Weekly bills - A weekly posting of local, regional, or national news that was usually posted in the town square.
 - Whitechapel - At the time of this document, Whitechapel was a parish just outside London that housed less fragrant industries like slaughterhouses, foundries, and breweries.
-

Questions:

1. What happened to many trades, businesses, and popular forms of entertainment as a result of the plague? How does that compare to what's happening today?
 2. What measures did Defoe and others take to try and protect themselves from contracting the sickness? How are those measures similar to steps people take today to protect themselves against epidemics? How are they different?
 3. What does Defoe say about the death toll, and why is that reminiscent of what we're seeing today with Covid-19?
 4. What major concern does Defoe bring up, near the end of the excerpt, regarding how the disease spreads? Compare and contrast that to how modern pandemics spread.
-

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1.5: "The disorder, I fear, increases-" Yellow Fever in Philadelphia, 1803

By Elizabeth Sandwith Drinker

Introduction:

Elizabeth Sandwith Drinker (c. 1735 – 1807) was a Quaker woman in Philadelphia who kept a diary from 1758 to 1807. Her husband, Henry, worked for an import business. Her diaries documented the changing medical practices in 18th century America. Yellow fever, also known as "American Plague," is a tropical disease and likely came to the United States aboard ships from Africa and the Caribbean that brought infected mosquitoes. These disease vectors thrived in the standing water and hot, humid summers in the Philadelphia area. The medical community did not understand the cause of the disease or how it was transmitted.

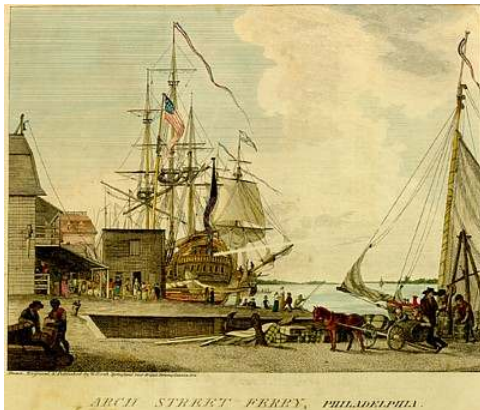
Symptoms of the disease include fever, chills, loss of appetite, nausea, muscle pains particularly in the back, and headaches. Some people develop jaundice due to liver damage, bleeding in the mouth, nose, the eyes, vomiting, kidney failure, and delirium. Those who develop more severe symptoms have a 50% fatality rate. There is no treatment for yellow fever. It can now be prevented with a vaccine and the eradication of the infected mosquito population.

Aug. 12. Our little dog Tartar barked last night from between 11 and 12 o'clock till near one, with very little abatement. I arose and went to ye window , but could not see ye cause . Something there was to set him agoing , as he is too fat and lazy to exert himself for nothing. 'Tis very rarely he barks.

....

September 21. Our neighbor Campbell called to say farewell. They leave the city to morrow, during the fever. Dr Wistar has said that the town is in better state at present, than for 10 days past.

Sept. 22. Ye Library is shut up for the present, and our evening paper is not sent, as ye printer is moving. We do not hear of many new cases of fever.



In 1803, Philadelphia was a busy port city.

"Arch Street Ferry in Philadelphia." by William Birch is in the [Public Domain](#)

A girl of ye name of Hannah Stringer, an intimate of our S. Dawson's, and a maid of neighbor Campbell's, has come, by Sall's invitation, to lodge here tonight. Girls who are running about the city at this time, without fear or care, are not desirable inmates. I did not like to refuse her, but shall not like a long continuance of her company.

Sept. 25. First day. One more of the few remaining old friends and acquaintances is departed! James Logan died this morning, I expect rather suddenly. I have not heard any particulars. About 2 or 3 weeks ago, I sent him some plums. He told Peter he was better than he had been, and was coming soon to visit us.

Sept 26. H. D. went in our waggon to the funeral of our friend J. Logan, this afternoon, at 4 o'clock. A short procession — no women there.

Sept. 28. This morning Sally Dawson was going to market, but complained of a pain in her head, and sick stomach. Sister told her she had better lay down, and not think of going out. Soon after, she vomited frequently. I sent for Dr Kuhn, knowing how imprudent Sally had been running out of nights &c. The Doctor said he hoped it was not ye yellow fever, but might turn out [to be] an intermittent fever. He ordered a puke of antimonial wine, and if her headache and fever continued, to have 8 ounces blood taken in ye evening. This evening she is, we hope, no worse, and fearing her arm might bleed in ye night, we have put off ye bleeding till morning. Judah tends her at night. She is very careful — I am not well enough to stay with her all night. I am very uneasy indeed on S. D's, and on our own account.

Sept, 29. Sally continued very ill, but not so much so as to alarm me much. Dr Kuhn came rather sooner than is common for him. He went up with me, and examined her eyes, which were red. On coming out of ye room he told me she had the yellow fever, and ordered 12 ounces of blood to be taken, and wrote a recipe to send to ye apothecary for pills of calomel &c. My husband and ye Doctor talked of sending her to ye Hospital. He said she would be taken as much care of there as she could be here, unless her mistress could attend constantly upon her, which I am not qualified to do. Were I in good health, and the rest of my family absent, I think I could undertake it, but that would not be allowed of. Ye Doctor wrote a note to ye Board of Health, and a carriage was sent about 3 o'clock p.m., in which she was taken. She shifted herself, and was dressed rather smartly; stood at ye kitchen door while her bed and bedclothes were put into the carriage. I wrote her a little letter to keep up her spirits. My husband wrote another to Dr Dorsey the attending physician, desiring his particular care of her. Poor child! as she is in the first stage of ye disorder, may it please kind Providence to restore her — but this we must leave. We have all felt weak and low since her absence. I am going to bed but not with much expectation of sleeping.

Sept. 30. Dr Kuhn kindly called this morning. The sending S. D. to the Hospital I believe was quite right; my mind is more at ease, tho' we have not yet heard how she is. Dr Kuhn says we may know by sending after dinner to Dr Duffield. I wrote a few lines to my daughter Nancy by ye stage, desiring her not to return in ye stage to town, but to stay till we send for her. The disorder, I fear, increases.

John Alsop called about dinnertime. He asked if we had heard from our girl. No, not yet. He had been to the Hospital this forenoon, where a servant girl of his was taken yesterday, just after ours. She was taken ill, and they sent for a Doctor, who said he could not say it was the yellow fever, but if she continued in the city it might become such, and advised them to send her to ye Hospital. He said he would go again tomorrow and let us know how Sally is.

Now if I had strength of body and firmness of mind to have undertaken ye care of our S. D., my family would not have suffered it, tho' I think, with Dr Kuhn's help, I might have brought her through. But I believe we have acted for the best; the symptoms with Sally were decided, I think — ye puke she took, ye copious bleeding of yesterday morning, and the mercurial pills she had taken before she left us, might have contributed to her amendment; but it is a deceitful disorder, and we must not flatter ourselves that she is out of danger, tho' seemingly better. People avoid our house, as we perhaps, should do ourselves. Sally's room has been cleaned, and her clothes washed — I believe there is no more infection in it now than there was a month ago. If I am clear, who was 3 or 4 times in her room the day she was taken, and twice the day after, when she was going away, to encourage and comfort her, and to keep her spirits up, which advice she did not appear to stand in much need of. My husband stood in almost, if not quite contact with the men who came for her. He took a paper from one of them and read it. We may, nevertheless, be preserved.



"A kitchen maid" by Hugues Taraval is in the [Public Domain](#)

October 1. John Alsop borrowed W. D's horse to go again to the Hospital. He brought a different account from yesterday. His girl continues better, but our poor Sally is very bad, and is delirious. She was blistered yesterday, which is no sign that she was much, if any better. John intends going again tomorrow.

We received an invitation to the passing of meeting of Charles Townsend and Prissy Kirk at Darby, next fifth day.

Our neighbor Christian Hahn, chocolate maker or grinder, shut up his house this morning, and went into ye country with his family. When they had arrived at ye destined place, Wm Hyatt got off his seat, holding ye reins in his hand, to assist in taking the baggage out. One of the horses was somehow frightened, or as they say, stung by a hornet. He became violent. William endeavored to hold him in, but he made a turn and upset the carriage, and broke it irreparably. It belongs to Molly Oliver, and will be a great loss to her — but that is not the worst of the business; a sister of C. Hahn had her arm broken, and her head badly bruised. I don't find that Wm Hyatt was anyways to blame; where there are two horses there should always be some one behind the carriage to open gates, let down ye steps, knock at doors &c.; but with Hacks, that cannot be expected.

My husband, sister, William and self were sitting this evening reading, apparently at our ease, while our poor Sally may be vomiting her life away, or be in the agony of death! Yet that may not be the case — she may be restored.

Oct. 3. John Alsop came in the forenoon. He had not been to the Hospital, but heard, upon enquiring that our Sally Dawson was gone. My husband brought a letter home from Dr Dorsey, wherein he informs us, "that the first indication he received of the malignancy of her case, was a considerable bleeding from the arm, which commenced before she arrived here," and which he found it for sometime difficult to check. Her symptoms abated the day after her arrival, but on ye next day, seventh day, she was seized with black vomiting which recurred seven times in the course of first day — and she expired this morning at a quarter before six o'clock, without having suffered, as she often told him, any pain, but weakness and a sick stomach. He thinks he has seen but few cases of more malignant disease than hers, and that Drs, Caldwell and Duffield coincide in this opinion. He finishes with saying —

"I trust you will do me the justice to believe that I made every exertion in my power to prevent this unfortunate termination of her malady."

Thus it is — a pretty girl, in the bloom of youth, with an high and independent spirit, is taken off the stage of life in no more than 5 days illness . A lesson for both the young and old.

Oct. 6. A letter from Jacob Downing; he is in town, but is, I expect, under some apprehensions of coming here. I don't wonder at it, though there is no danger; we have been very careful to have Sally's room, which is over the kitchen, thoroughly cleaned. He tells us in his letter that a waggon from Downingtown is now here, and we could go with him tomorrow. I asked my husband what he thought of Jacob's proposal; he said — nothing at all . So that there is no probability of our leaving ye city.

Oct. 16. It is two weeks tomorrow since Sally's death. I wish to know how she seemed in her mind during her illness. When ye fever is over, and the City Hospital closed, I shall endeavor, if I live, to see Dr Dorsey, who attended her while there.

Oct. 19. A young man over the way, next door to the barber's, died last night. Peter saw a horse and some sort of carriage at ye door when he went to bed, and this morning Sister and Paul saw a bed sent away from ye house in a cart. The man who put it in the cart stood by Campbell's wall and puked. We know nothing of this illness. He has left a young wife, who is daughter to ye man of the house. I know not their names — they have been married but 6 months. Their windows have been opened

all day, and the room whitewashed. There can be no doubt of the disorder; many keep it private.

....

Oct. 30. First day. The sun arose, I believe clear, as I saw it shine on Pratt's buttonwood tree. Nancy Dawson called before meeting. She had not heard of her sister Sally's death till this morning. She has not heard anything of her sister Betsy, who said she was going to New-York sometime last year. 'Tis not unlikely she may be dead, if so, I told Nancy, she would be entitled to all poor Sally left; that we had not yet opened her trunk, not knowing but that something she had worn while sick was in it. When frosty weather came, we would bring it into the yard, and air the clothes, and take a list of all she had, which should be kept for her until she was free, unless we should hear from Betsy, who, if living, is entitled to one half. Nancy is between 15 and 16 years of age.

November 8. Judah and Peter went this afternoon to ye negro meeting. Many will not call ye black people negroes. 'Tis thought by some rather a harsh appellation , but as it is a common name for them, and Niger is, I believe, the Latin term for them, or for black, I think there is no impropriety in it. Have they not always been so called? Africans and Ethiopians indeed! Those here are neither.

Nov. 15. The old story of cold in my head and cough, which is an affliction that I am often troubled with.

Nov. 16. W, D. called on Dr Kuhn, who came here between 11 and 12 o'clock. He advised the loss of 10 ounces of blood, which was taken from my right arm before 12 o'clock, by John Hailer. My cough continues very hard.

Nov. 17. My husband weighed the Bowl with the blood yesterday, 22½ oz. He weighed ye bowl today, 9½ oz; so that instead of 10 ounces, I lost thirteen.

Non. 18, Dr Kuhn came this morning. He advised me to stay a few days in my chamber, but as I feel rather better this evening, I believe I shall not, as it is disagreeable to me to be confined up stairs when I can do otherwise.

Nov. 19. The Dr called and said he wished I would stay in my chamber — the frequent passing thro' ye entry, and coming up and down stairs, renewed my cold; if the cough were not better in a day or two, I must lose more blood. He ordered a medicine to cut the phlegm. I am now up stairs, and how long I shall remain so, I cannot judge.

December 8. James Pemberton informed H.D. of the death of Joseph Galloway — who died in August last, in what part of old England, I did not hear.

Dec. 12, W.D. went to Dr Duffields', and gave ye Docr a list of what Sally Dawson took to ye Hospital. He said he would enquire after them, and further said, which I most desired to know, that Sally when in the Hospital made little complaint or moaning — as many others did. That she was very much debilitated, and her blood dissolved; that she had the disorder in a very malignant degree; that it generally proved fatal to Girls; that she lived but 3 days after her coming there.

William asked him if he thought she would have lived could she have had the best of nursing at home. He answered, No, she could not. All this is rather satisfactory than otherwise.

Dec. 14. The old man back of our stable has commenced a suit against Henry Pratt, Henry Drinker, and Isaac Knight. His premises, he said, were injured by the liquid from some of the dungheaps , running on his ground. The matter is to settle from whose dungheap it proceeds. The old man died last spring, and his widow is lately married to Wm Hyatt.

Glossary:

- “&c” - archaic form of etc., meaning “and other things.”
- abatement - a lessening, diminution, or reduction; a moderation; removal or putting an end to; the suppression of.
- affliction - a disease; a state of pain and suffering.
- amendment - the change for the better; healing.
- apothecary - a person who makes and provides/sells drugs and/or medicines.
- appellation - a name, title or designation.
- “by ye stage” - short for stagecoach, the carriages that would transport people and small packages.
- “commenced a suit” - began to sue or otherwise bring to court on legal grounds.
- continuance - the action of continuing or prolonging.
- copious - having an abundant supply.
- debilitated - weakened; damaged.
- “fifth day” - Thursday, usually used in Quaker society. (Quakers rejected the use of the names of days of the week that were derived from the names of pagan gods.)
- “first day” - Sunday
- forenoon - the part of the day between sunrise and noon; morning.
- impropriety - having a quality of impropriety; being rude.
- imprudent - not prudent; lacking discretion; not attentive to consequence; improper.
- “inflammatory rheumatism” - a disease causing pain and stiffness in joints.
- inmates - a person who shares a residence, such as a lodger.
- intimate - a very close friend.
- malady - a disease or illness.
- malignancy - the state of being malignant or harmful; the state of being deadly.
- “mercurial pills” - pills of mercury used to induce urination and bowel movements.
- minute - a short moment of time; a part of a meeting.
- upset - to turn over or capsize.
- “passing of meeting” - Quaker marriages required that the couple bring their request to be married to their congregation for their approval. If their marriage is approved, the couple is said to have “passed meeting.” (Bernard, Ella Kent. [Dorothy Payne, Quakeress: A Side-light Upon the Career of "Dolley" Madison](#) . Philadelphia: Ferris & Leech, 1909.)
- “pills of calomel” - pills containing a mineral composed of mercury and chloride, used as both a sedative and laxative.
- Providence - divine care or direction, the will of God; fate.
- “puke of antimonial wine” - wine containing antimony that was designed to make a person throw up, an emetic.
- Rising Sun - East.
- Sall’s - a nickname for Sally Dawson.
- simple - dim-witted; foolish; lacking intelligence; often used for those with learning or intellectual disabilities.
- whitewashed - painted over with a lime and water mixture to both brighten and sanitize walls or fences.
- Wm - shorthand for “William.”

Questions:

1. Quarantined families have to decide whether family members should associate with others outside of the household since any contact one person has with others has the potential to bring infection into the household. Is this a problem you have encountered? If so, how did your family handle it?
2. How does yellow fever spread? How did the people in Philadelphia in 1803 think it spread? Did social distancing and stay-at-home help slow the spread of the virus?
3. Mention is made numerous times about people having blood removed. Why do you think doctors used bleeding as a remedy for illnesses like Yellow Fever?

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1.6: “We have a terrible sickness here at this place-” Smallpox on the Ottawa Reservation in Peshawbestown, Michigan, 1881

Introduction:

In the fall of 1881, two Native American men helped to unload two schooners that docked in Traverse City. In the process, they contracted smallpox from one of the people on the boats and took the infection back to the Ottawa reservation in Peshawbestown on the Leelanau peninsula. The infection spread and, in an effort to contain it, health officials quarantined the entire village and the residents were not able to buy food or get medical help.

These letters were exchanged between Francis Blackman, a Native American from Peshawbestown, Dr. Horace Nelson, a physician from Northport (the village north of Peshawbestown), George Lee of the Mackinac Office of Indian Affairs in Ypsilanti, and Hiram Price, the Commissioner of Indian Affairs in Washington D.C. from 1881 to 1885. Father Philip Zorn was the Franciscan priest in Cross Village across the Bay who was responsible for the Catholic missions in Leelanau County.

Francis Blackman, Suttons Bay, Peshobatown , to George Lee, Nov. 9, 1881

We have a terrible sickness here at this place. 5 dead more since I wrote to you, and 16 taking sick already 7 dead here at this place, besides 1 at Suttons Bay and 1 at Elk Rapids. The Indians are hard up, can not work to get their provisions all they have to do to give some fire wood , those who are able to go around, one of my brothers house, most every body is sick, he is sick himself except 2 little girls cannot do much anything. We need lots of help at this place. Some of them getting [scared] for their group. We need flour pork cornmeal and tea, and we throwing a way our clothes, which we wear when its first come out the sickness. I was throw out pants stockings under shirts twice.

Doctor from Northport came to see me today. He is a surgeon . He was in the [area] you can find his name at Anabor or in Generals Office at detroit Michigan. His name is Dr. Horace W. Nelson Northport Lelanaw county Mich. I am not very sick I can set up on my bead. Doctor called this my sickness this is varioloid. I do not know what kind they have the others. The doctor at Suttons Bay he don't come here. I suppose he got [scared]. I can not attend to your business.

My sister she is begun to sick too. This is all I have to say very respect to you.

Peshaba Town Oct 9th 1881
 Mr. George W. Lee 2000,
 Dear Sir
 We have a terrible sickness
 here at this Place 5 dead more
 since i wrote to you, and
 16 taking Sick all ready.
 7 Dead here at this Place, besides
 1, at Suttons Bay and, 1, at Elk rapids
 the Indians are hard up. cannot
 work to get their Provisions
 all they have to do, to give some
 Fire Wood, those who are able to
 go around, one of my Brothers
 house, most every body sick
 he is sick him self except
 2 little girls, can not do much
 any thing. We need lots of
 help at this Place. some of them
 getting scarce for their grub.
 we need Flour Pork corn meal & tea. and we
 throwing a way our cloths which we
 wear when its first come out the sickness

Letter from Francis Blackman, Peshawbestown, MI, to George Lee, Mackinac Office of Indian Affairs, 1881.

Dr. Horace Nelson to George Lee, Nov. 9, 1881

Francis Blackman of Peshawbestown has requested me to write to you in reference to the conditions of the Indians in his locality. At the request by letter of Father Zorn, the Indian Missionary (Catholic) I visited all the houses in the village in which there was sickness, I found the disease to be small pox or the confluent type which is the most malignant of all.

In one home there were 8 cases lying upon the floor one old man (nearly blind) to wait upon them. He himself was taken today. His wife now waits upon them all. She informed Father Zorn that they had eaten up all their provisions and their last potato was gone. He magnanimously paid all his money to buy them corn meal (\$250) and ordered an Indian Andrew Chippewa to distribute the meal in lots of 10 to 50 [10 words illegible] is young man of 24 years of age. 2 days before I notified the poor master of this district of the starvation of the Indians of this locality, but he refused to give or allow them anything as they were all well off and could buy what they wanted. I asked him how could they do so? When they were not allowed to come to the whites and buy. They may have lands, if so, they have no money, and therefore cannot buy. Of course, want or care and no nourishment will aggravate the disease, and cause the utmost privation and distress and hurry death. On my return to Northport where I reside, I was told I was forbidden to visit the Indians again, that the Board of Health has ordered their Supervisor to stop me and prevent me at all hazards. The Indians of that locality have requested me to come again to them with disinfectants and also to vaccinate those who are still free of the disease, as they are not allowed to leave the place. I promised to do so, as soon as I received some fresh vaccine virus from Detroit and which I expected daily. This action of the board stops me. My inclination is to go. What shall I do? I must await your orders. If you say to go, I'll go, but I will expect you to pay me for my services, as I will be obliged to relinquish all my other practice while I attend to the Indians. One Indian woman aborted this morning, herself and one of her children down with it, both likely to be sacrificed to the disease. They have asked the mail carrier who passes through their village to carry a letter for you, which he positively refused to do, they have offered him money to bring them supplies and to pay him well for doing so. He still refused. What are the poor Indians to do? I am sorry to say that there is great apathy amongst the whites who think if the Indians are taken away by death they can buy their lands (which are very desirable) very cheap. The supervisor of Bingham (in which township Peshawbetown is located) said that he would relieve the Indian "Pontiac" whose family and relations were all sick because he had 60 acres of land and would not sell it, although a man name Calico Johnson had offered to buy the wood upon it or part of it and give him what provisions he wanted. This he told voluntarily to their Priest Father Zorn. So from this fact you can judge the feelings of some people in this vicinity. Today I counted 17 cases sick with this disease.

I should mention to you that the above named supervisor, said that if I attended the Indians he would not allow me to be paid for my services in case I applied to the County board so you see he is in the employ of the wood buyers. There is a young physician in Suttons Bay about 4 miles from Peshawbetown, who attended the first case there, and also the next, but did not inform the friend of the patients that it was the smallpox. They blame him. For had he told them, they would have taken measures to protect themselves and stopped the progress of the disease. They say he did not know what it was until too late, when they knew it themselves.

Francis Blackman has varisoid and may take the smallpox from his sister who is lying on the floor within 6 feet of him. If not he will be able to do your business by the latter part of the ensuing [week]. Will you please inform me by return of mail what you wish me to do, in reference to my medical services with the Indians. (I was asst serg of the 11th [illegible] [Awaiting your reply, Dr. Horace Nelson]



Ojibwe/Chippewa mother and child, 1880.

"Domestic scene, Chippewa Indians." by New York Public Library is in the [Public Domain](#)

George Lee to Hon. H[iram] Price, Commissioner of Indian Affairs, Nov. 11, 1881

I enclose the letters of an Indian Francis Blackman and one Dr. Nelson and ask immediate directions. One cannot think such barbarity could exist among a civilized people.

Please give me instruction in the matter. I shall of course give immediate temporary relief but it must be of more extent than I can venture. There are probably two or three hundred people in the village and the idea that the people will not help because they have some wild land is preposterous.

[Note: We do not have Hiram Price's response to Lee's request for instructions.]

Dr. [Horace] Nelson (Northport) to Geo. Lee, Nov. 18, 1881

Yours of the 11th was received after dark, of the 15th at 7:50 pm your telegram was also recd. In accordance with your request, I proceeded next morning in horse and buggy. Two miles from the village I was stopped by a man who told me he was ordered to stop me if I attempted to go to Peshawbestown. I told him that my life was just as precious to me and to my family as any individual had of theirs and as I had not been notified by the board of health of any obstruction to a physician attending to his patients, I should go where I pleased, and I did so. When I got to Peshawbestown, I found things greatly improved. The Township of Bingham has employed a Mr. Wm. Keyes to attend to the Indians, and to (words missing) necessities of life, such as flour, crackers, corn meal and tea and rice. He calls upon the Indians twice a day, and ask them what they want. He orders them to keep [to] their house (which they faithfully do) where there is sickness. I spent an hour in the school house with this man, seeing how he managed in regard to the distribution of supplies. His method was good. He weighed so much meal, crackers, flour, rice, tea and entered the same upon a book with the name of the Indian who received it. He has also a supply of carbolic acid in the crystal form which he dissolves in water and gives an ounce of it to each Indian and explains its use. I believe the man is doing good. He sleeps in the school house which is centrally located so when any of their family are taken sick, they are told to go to the school house and he will give them [illegible] to use. On my entrance to the village I proceeded to the residence of Francis Blackman, read to him your letter and also told him your order by telegraph. He is now convalescent and waiting upon his two nieces who are now both suffering from the smallpox. I examined them and told him I had no hopes for the youngest. I left some medicine for them, but am afraid it is too late. His sister who was just taken at [my] last visit and of which I informed you is now recovered and assists him in attending his two nieces. I proceeded to the house of Nannegoi, a house which on my first visit had 8 cases. One of them I told them would die in 24 hours. Only lived till next morning. The brother lying on the floor within 3 feet of her had just caught the disease. I gave him medicine and [words missing] sister and cousin all down with it lying upon the floor. It is a very hard place for a young man of 20 convalescing and the cousin dying. His name is Joe Penaswagesek about 15 years of age. The next house I called was that of Joe Blackman, who died last night of ten days sickness. (This is the brother of Francis Blackman and the father of the two girls sick in his house.) I found his wife recovering from the small pox, but very feeble and emaciated. I think I told you that I found that she had miscarried on my second visit. She will gather strength but only slow. Her older daughter has the disease in its severest type. And little hopes of her. Also previous to making these calls I proceeded to the house of Lapesaw, I think the third house from Blackman and commenced to vaccinate with the virus I had received a few days before from Detroit. I vaccinated 32 and will vaccinate all of the Indians I can reach when I receive your supply. I have vaccinated the following [lists names of persons vaccinated.]

The family suffered very severely nearly to be exterminated. Mitchell Agosa died last night and also his father, mother, and grandchild, and two of his children a few days before. The [illegible] with Joe Blackman make 5 deaths last evening. I think in all this [illegible] 17 deaths, during the week 3 more will go. I believe the disease is checked, and with the exception of the cases named, the greatest number will recover. I did not purchase any meat or flour as you requested, because as the supervisor of Bingham had seen the error of his ways, and was redeeming his good name by having a wagon load of supplies sent from Suttons Bay to Peshawbestown 3 times a week and I believe Mr. Keyes will do them justice. I think him a good and honest man, who will faithfully distribute the supplies. I have therefore retained your kind offer for a case of emergency if such should occur, and will see that it is properly distributed. I forgot to mention that some of those I vaccinated were revaccinations which had not taken, and I shall repeat the operation again in the course of a few days unless I am stopped on the highway by force. Can any Board of Health stop a physician on the highway when he is on an errand of mercy and the saving of lives? They tell me that they have more powers vested in them than any court in the state. It may be so, but I don't believe it. Can you advise me as their legality in stopping and preventing me going?

This township of Leelanaw has done nothing for the relief of the Indians, unless it be the place of a man to guard the road [and paying] him for doing so. The Poor Master, refusing to see to their necessities when I told him it was his duty and his district. No such fear of the Indians starving while they have plenty of land and etc. The nearest he visited them was one mile from his own home and 3 miles of the village.

Glossary:

- carbolic acid - an antiseptic mixture pioneered by Joseph Lister for treating and sterilizing wounds, surfaces, and utensils.
 - confluent - one of the two forms of smallpox along with semi-confluent smallpox, with confluent being the most deadly.
 - poor master - the county or township official who was responsible for distributing aid to the poor people in the community. This was the only social welfare available during that time.
 - privation - being deprived of basic human necessities.
 - varioloid - a mild form of smallpox affecting people who have already had the disease or have been vaccinated against it.
-

Questions:

1. What do the actions of the Poor Master and the Board of Health, as related by Dr. Horace Nelson's letter, tell us about attitudes toward Native Americans in the late 19th century?
 2. What do we learn about smallpox and how it affects people from the excerpts presented here?
-

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1.7: “I have used my best effort in a kind way-” Smallpox among the Hopi, 1898

“I have used my best effort in a kind way:” Smallpox among the Hopi, 1898

By G.W. Hayzlett

Introduction:

George Washington Hayzlett was a businessman and local politician from Black Hawk County, Iowa, who, at the age of 61, moved with his wife to Fort Defiance on the Navajo Indian Reservation in Arizona to serve as agent for the Bureau of Indian Affairs. Hayzlett’s annual reports to the Commission of Indian Affairs in Washington, D.C. reflect the paternalistic attitude toward Native Americans common to the times. However, he worked hard to improve the infrastructure of the reservation and supply the people with the things they needed to farm the land and provide for themselves.

Moqui is the name the Hopi Indians called themselves. The Hopi are a tribe descended from the Ancestral Pueblo peoples who built the apartment-like dwellings on the mesas. Hopis had farmed for centuries and had a long-standing agricultural tradition and sophisticated methods that enabled them to subsist in a dry and inhospitable climate. They were known to be peaceful people in contrast to warring tribes that survived by raiding.

The Moqui Reservation is located due west of the south half of the Navajo Reservation and bounded on the east and north by the Navajo Reservation, and embraces a territory of about 55 miles east and west and 65 miles north and south. The general appearance of the country differs somewhat from that of the Navajo Reservation, containing more level land, a very large portion of which is very sandy. The water supply is very limited. In some cases they have to carry the water from 1 to 2 miles; and the wood problem has been very serious with some of them, as the wood has usually been carried on burros from 3 to 4 miles. But this difficulty has been greatly relieved, as the Government in the last year has placed on the reservation for the Moquis some forty wagons, which will quite well supply them, they living as they do on top of the mesa in villages very compact, so that a great number can use the same wagon.

The Moqui is quite provident. They seem to have a good idea that in time of plenty they should prepare for famine. This was fully demonstrated this spring after the smallpox scourge had abated and the time came for cleaning up and fumigating and disinfecting their houses. It was found they had an abundance of corn and dried peaches stored away in their houses; they claimed a supply for two years ahead. This fully demonstrates that they are not living for to-day only, but preparing for their future subsistence. They are industrious and appear to be a very quiet and peaceful people. Very seldom do they have any serious trouble among themselves. Their domestic relations are very superior to that of the Navajo. They are not polygamists—do not believe in plural marriages. However, they do sometimes separate and remarry, but not so frequently.



Picture of a Pueblo in Oraibi, Arizona

"Hopi (Moqui) Indians snake kiva Oraibi Pueblo" by [Library of Congress](#) is in the [Public Domain](#)

An epidemic of smallpox broke out among these people about the 10th of December, 1898, which resulted in 187 deaths. Fatalities occurred very largely among those who were obstinate and refused to receive medical aid from the Government physician. Miss M. H. McKee, M. D., who is the school physician at Keams Canyon as soon as advised of the contagion existing in the Moqui villages, accompanied Mr. Samuel E. Shoemaker, head farmer, who was in charge of the Moqui Indians

under the direction of the agent, proceeded at once to the villages and began a general vaccination of all who would submit, and at the same time rendering medical assistance to those who were sick so far as they would submit to our manner of treating the sick. Unfortunately a great many absolutely refused either to be vaccinated or receive medical treatment. Of 632 who had the smallpox, 412 were willing to receive treatment from our physician, and out of that number of cases 24 died, and of the other 220 who would not receive treatment from our physician 163 died.

Every precaution possible was taken to prevent the spread of the disease, it having

broken out about the same time on the first and second mesa. To prevent further spread a quarantine was maintained by police being stationed at intervals between the second mesa and Oraibi; thus we kept it confined to the two mesas. Had they been obedient and adopted our mode of treatment the death rate would have been very much less.

When the time came for cleaning up their villages, burning their infected clothing, fumigating and disinfecting their houses, there still existed a hostile element that refused to have this done, and to enforce the orders it became necessary to call on the Indian Office for military assistance, which was readily granted. A cavalry troop of 30 men was sent from Fort Wingate, and on their arrival at the mesa where the trouble existed the Indians were still stubborn and refused to be washed and reclothed, but the troops soon subdued them without any serious injury to anyone. Eight of the leaders in the hostile element were arrested and taken to the agency and confined in the jail. Had it not been for a few of such leaders we would have had no serious trouble, but they controlled an element, consisting of nearly one-fourth of the entire tribe, who now claim to be pleased that the leaders are punished. I have used my best effort in a kind way to teach these prisoners that they were wrong; that the Government was their best friend and

guardian. They finally acknowledge that the civilized mode of treatment for the sick is best, and should another outbreak of the disease occur they would be obedient and receive treatment from our physicians.

But they still insist that they do not believe in educating their children. This class of the Moqui have never patronized the school to any extent, but there is still hope that they may be made to realize the necessity of education.

The Government has assisted the Indians in building 96 houses on the bottom lands where the farming is carried on. Nearly every one of these houses is occupied during the summer while the crops are being raised and harvested, after which the Indians move back to their villages on the mesa, carry their crops up and store them in their houses, and remain there through the winter. A few families remain in the houses on the farms the entire year.

Glossary:

- burro - Spanish loanword for donkeys.
- mesa - a raised plateau or mountain with a flat top with cliff-like edges.
- provident - having great care and consideration for the future; possessing forethought.
- Pueblo - a multistory stone building that serves as a permanent residence for a Native American population.

Questions:

1. How did the government employees help treat those Natives who had contracted smallpox?
2. Mention is made here of a faction of Natives resistant to the recommendations being made by the government physician . Why do you think they were resistant? Could that resistance have anything to do with past relations between Native American tribes and the US government?
3. Compare and contrast what's going on with this outbreak with the one recorded in Peshawbestown in the previous document.

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1.8: “We sure did get tired-” Letter from a Volunteer Nurse, October 17, 1918

“We sure did get tired:” Letter from a Volunteer Nurse, October 17, 1918

By Lutiant Lavoye

Introduction:

Lutiant Lavoye was a Chippewa girl from Minnesota who graduated from the Haskell Indian School in Kansas and, at age 19, volunteered to help nurse soldiers in Camp Humphreys near Washington, D.C during the Influenza epidemic in October of 1918. This is a letter she wrote to her friend at the school. After only a week or so, staff at the camp hospital sent Lutiant home because the patients were so sick and she was too inexperienced.

Unfortunately, the Haskell school officials read her letter to Louise and she was reprimanded for her remark about Head Matron Katherine Keck and cooking teacher Mae McCauley. Miss Keck was very unpopular with the Indian girls in the dormitory and was later transferred from the school.

To read more about Lutiant and the school, see the articles listed at the end of this reading.

Dear friend Louise:

So everybody has the “Flu” at Haskell? I wish to goodness Miss Keck and Mrs. McK. would get it and die with it. Really, it would be such a good riddance, and not much lost either! As many as 90 people die every day here with the “Flu.” Soldiers too, are dying by the dozens. So far, Felicity, C. Zane, and I are the only ones of the Indian girls who have not had it. We certainly consider ourselves lucky too, believe me. Katherine and I just returned last Sunday evening from Camp Humphreys “Somewhere in Virginia” where we volunteered to help nurse soldiers sick with the Influenza. ... All nurses were required to work twelve hours a day—we worked from seven in the morning until seven at night, with only a short time for luncheon and dinner.

Believe me, we were always glad when night came because we sure did get tired. We had the actual Practical nursing to do—just like the other nurses had, and were given a certain number of wards with three or four patients in each of them to look after. Our chief duties were to give medicines to the patients, take temperatures, fix ice packs, feed them at “eating time”, rub their back or chest with camphorated sweet oil, make egg-nogs, and a whole string of other things I can’t begin to name. I liked the work just fine, but it was too hard, not being used to it. When I was in the Officer’s barracks, four of the officers of whom I had charge, died. Two of them were married and called for their wife nearly all the time. It was sure pitiful to see them die. I was right in the wards alone with them each time, and Oh! The first one that died sure unnerved me—I had to go to the nurses’ quarters and cry it out. The other three were not so bad. Really, Louise, Orderlies carried the dead soldiers out on stretchers at the rate of two every three hours for the first two days they were there. Two German spies, posing as doctors, were caught giving these Influenza germs to the soldiers and they were shot last Saturday at sunrise. It is such a horrible thing, it is hard to believe, and yet such things happen almost every day in Washington.



Emergency hospital in Camp Funston, Kansas, in the midst of the influenza epidemic.

"Emergency hospital during influenza epidemic" by National Museum of Health and Medicine is licensed under CC BY 4.0

Repeated calls come from the Red Cross for nurses to do district work right here in D. C. I volunteered again, but as yet I have not been called and am waiting. Really, they are certainly "hard up" for nurses—even me can volunteer as a nurse in a camp or in Washington. There are about 800 soldiers stationed at Potomac Park right here in D. C. just a short distance from the Interior building where I work, and this morning's paper said that the deaths at this Park were increasing, so if fortune favors me, I may find myself there before the week is ended. I have a very dear soldier friend who is stationed there—Lt. Cantril by name. 'Twas so funny how we first met. I was completely lost in St. Louis at the Union station (on my way to D.C.) and simply had no idea where I was going—just wandering around the station to pass away my 3 ½ hrs. there waiting for my train. Finally, I thought of sending Odile a telegram so she could be at the station to meet me. I went to the Postal office right there in the Station and this soldier was standing there waiting to send a telegram too I waited, waited, and waited and could not get in to send one, so I picked up my suit case and traveling bag and started toward the Ladies' Waiting room. Instead of taking my own traveling bag, I left mine and picked up this soldier's bag. They were as much alike as two peas, and I was so tired I never took special notice, but I thought I had my own bag. When I opened it to get out my comb and powder—behold! There was a kit-bag fully equipped and a knitted sweater in it, plus a few other trinkets. I knew then, whose bag I had, so checked my suit case and started to look for this soldier and exchange bags, as I thought he had mine. After walking around 45 minutes I began to despair of ever finding him and started back to the Ladies room and I came upon him sitting in one corner. I recognized my bag right away and went to exchange. He was simply so tickled to get his bag back he almost squeezed the life out of my hand when he shook it. I had my card and destination tacked on the handle of my bag, so he found out where I was going without telling him—and as fate would have it—he was going to D.C. too, so we traveled the rest of the way together. He is a perfect gentleman, and sure treated me nice on the way. Since I am located here, he has been down to our house twice to see me since I came back from Camp Humphreys, and he sure wants me to come down to Potomac Park as a nurse. He is not what one would call "handsome" but he is certainly good-looking, and on top of all that—he is CATHOLIC. Sure like it for myself too. All the girls have soldiers—Indian girls also. Some of the girls have soldiers and sailors too. The boys are particularly crazy about the Indian girls. They tell us that the Indian girls are not so "easy" as the white girls, so I guess maybe that's their reason.



LUTIANT LA VOYE.

"Lutiant Lavoye" by [National Archives at Kansas City](#) is in the [Public Domain](#)

Washington is certainly a beautiful place. There is so much to be said in favor of it, that if I started, I don't believe I should ever get through. Odile and I have to pass by the Capitol, the Union Station, the War Department, the Pension Bldg., and through the noted Lincoln park every morning to our way to work. The Washington Monument (555ft. high) is within walking distance of the Interior Department (where we work) and we walked there last evening after work. It certainly is high and we are planning to go up in the elevator some time to look over the city. We were going last evening, but the place is closed temporarily, on account of this "Flu".

The Aviation field is another very interesting place here. Air-planes fly over the cit at all hours of the day now, and sometimes so low that one can hear the noise of the machine.

Besides Aviators, we have hundreds of soldiers, sailors, Marines, French "Blue Devils " and even the National band of Italy here in Washington. Douglas Fairbanks and Geraldine Farrar are here also on the fourth Liberty Loan campaign and I was privileged to take a chance to peep at them. Just yesterday, Bouglas sold ONE MILLION DOLLARS WORTH OF BONDS FOR WASHINGTON. It was rumoured that Washington was going to fail to reach its quota in Liberty Bonds on account of having so many deaths and sick people in the city, but the way "Doug" is selling 'em, it doesn't seem as if it will. A lot of girls from the Office here go out to sell bonds but some of them don't make much of a success. One of the Indian girls, named Cathryne Welch, went out last week to sell bonds and seh sold so many that she got recused from the Office for the rest of this week to do nothing but sell bonds. She is a very pretty girl--a high school graduate and one year normal. She has two brothers in the army--one is a Captain and the other a Sergeant. Maybe you remember seeing Capt. Gus Welch's picture in the K. C. Star--well that is her brother and he is "over there" now.

All the schools, churches, theaters, dancing halls, etc. are closed here also. There is a bill in the Senate today authorizing all the war-workers to be released from work for the duration of this epidemic. It has not passed the house yet, but I can't help but hope it does. If it does, Lutiant can find plenty of things at home to busy herself with, or she might accidentally take a trip to Potomac Park. Ha! Ha!

It is perfectly alright about the sweater. I don't expect you to be able to get it while you are quarantined, but will still be glad to have it if you can send it as soon as you are out of quarantine. It is rather cold in Washington, but not cold enough to wear winter coats yet, and my suit coat is a little too thin, so I figured out that a sweater would be the thing to have. Sometimes it is cold enough to wear a wrap while working, but of course, it is out of the question to work in a heavy winter coat. However, send it whenever you find it convenient to do so, and I will settle with you as promptly as possible.

Well Louise, if you are not dead tired reading this letter, I'll write another like it some other time. There is still a lot I could tell you about D.C., but it's nearing lunch time and I want to be right there on the dot, as I always am--to be sure.

Write again whenever you find it convenient to do so--always glad to hear the Kaskell news from you.

Sincerely your friend,

Lutiant

Glossary:

- Kit-bag - another name for a duffle bag.
 - “one year normal” - normal school is one that trains high school graduates to become teachers.
-

Questions:

1. What duties is Lutiant responsible for as a volunteer nurse? What kind of toll did performing those duties take on her and other volunteers?
 2. What similarities do you see between what’s happening in Washington, DC, due to the flu and how cities and states are reacting to the current epidemic?
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1.9: “Volunteers Required-” Newspaper Articles on Spanish Flu from Wausau, Wisconsin 64

“Volunteers Required:” Newspaper Articles on Spanish Flu from Wausau, Wisconsin

Introduction:

More than 8,000 Wisconsin residents died in the 1918-1919 influenza epidemic. These articles from the Wausau, Wisconsin newspaper show how the community coped with the epidemic and the efforts of civic organizations to mitigate the spread of the disease. Public health officials educated people on the use of quarantine, masks, hand-washing, social distancing and provided help for citizens stricken with influenza.

The women’s committees of the World War I era were a federally organized effort to put women’s labor and domestic skills to use while the men were away at war. The work of the women’s committees was portrayed as the “home-front defense.” They addressed issues such as women’s and children’s health, food and nutrition, and other social welfare needs. Interestingly enough, the relationships, organization, and leadership skills developed during the war years laid the foundation of the women’s suffrage movement that followed in the 1920s.

HOMES CANVASSED FOR “FLU” CENSUS

Women Visit Households to Determine Number of Cases in the City

VOLUNTEERS REQUIRED

Conditions in Many Homes Indicate Need of Emergency Workers

Seventy women under the direction of the city health officer today began visiting homes in allotted districts to ascertain the number of cases of influenza in the city, to determine whether each case is in charge of a physician and to note the number of persons afflicted in each home, the condition of the sick, also the condition of the household as to cleanliness and ventilation, the need of help and the kind of assistance required. Circulars were distributed by the women which read as follows:

Caution:

Oftentimes it is impossible to tell a cold from mild influenza. Therefore if you get a cold go to bed in a well ventilated room. Keep warm. Keep away from the other people. Do not kiss any one . Use individual basins and knives, forks, spoons, towels, handkerchiefs, soap, wash plates and cups.

Every case of influenza should go to bed at once under the care of a physician. The patient should stay in bed at least three days after fever has disappeared and until convalescence is well established.

The patient must not cough or sneeze except when a mask or handkerchief is held before the face.

He should be in a warm, well ventilated room.

There is no specific [treatment] for the disease. Symptoms should be met as they arise.

The great danger is from pneumonia. Avoid it by staying in bed while actually ill and until convalescence is fully established.

The after-effects of influenza are worse than the disease. Take care of yourself. Strictly observe the state and city rules and regulations for the control of influenza.



Home Workers Needed

The woman's committee of the Council of Defense is assisting the health department in this work. The urgent need of help in homes where there are several persons ill was announced today by Mrs. W.H. Nablo, chairman of the women's committee, and also by Mrs. E. F. Stockum, field worker for the Federated Charities. Persons who can prepare food, wash dishes, keep the home clean, etc. are required and if necessary, they will be paid by the city and Federated Charities. Visiting nurses will call at the homes, but there are not sufficient nurses to permit that the nurses do work about the household. They will attend to the needs of the patient.



Poster distributed by the American Red Cross in 1917-1918

"Influenza Wear Your Mask It May Save Your Life" by American National Red Cross is in the [Public Domain](#)

The conditions in a large majority of homes are bad according to nurses and volunteer workers who have visited these households. In many instances the home fires are burning at a high pitch and all windows and sources of ventilation are closed. The volunteer workers have been forced to remedy these conditions by shutting off the stove draft and opening windows. Many of the mothers are exhausted from overwork and it is feared that unless more volunteer workers offer their assistance, these mothers may themselves become ill and owing to their already weakened condition, may develop pneumonia. It is therefore imperative that more offer their services as volunteer workers. Women aged from twenty-five to forty are preferred for this work.

The Woman's Motor Squad, of which Mrs. D.C. Everest is captain, and many other women who have automobiles at their disposal, aided the woman's committee of the Council of Defense today in getting the volunteer workers to the various sections of the city in which they are assigned to work, also in transporting visiting nurses, etc. to and from homes afflicted with influenza.



American Red Cross Volunteer nurses making surgical dressings while wearing masks in Oakland, California.

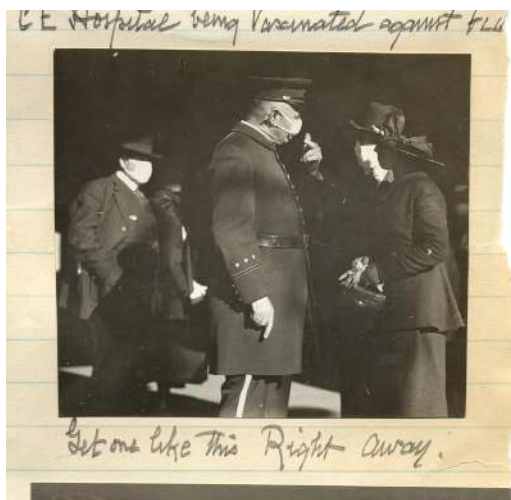
"American Red Cross volunteers of 1917-1918 preparing surgical dressings [picture]." by Edward A. "Doc" Rogers is in the [Public Domain](#).

Will Make Reports

The women who visited the homes today for information will send in reports this evening to the city health officer. They are instructed to handle all cases with diplomacy, keep a certain distance from those afflicted without arousing any ill-feeling, teach the members of the households the use of the face mask whenever attending the family and use it themselves whenever required. The face mask, they were told, should be thrown in boiling water whenever necessary to be cleaned. They were told to warn all members of afflicted households to wash their hands frequently and not to use eating and drinking utensils in common. All dishes should be thoroughly cleaned, all rooms kept clean and well ventilated and handkerchiefs, towels and linens used about the sick boiled or destroyed. Also not to spread or contract the disease from their neighbors by unnecessary calls or neighborly visits, nor by allowing children from various households to mingle on the streets or the premises.

Patrolling Streets

The police have been ordered to keep a close lookout for all children found playing on streets or on premises other than at their own homes.



This work ([Policeman warning citizen to don flu mask], by Dobbin, Hamilton Henry, 1856-1930.), identified by [Calisphere](#) , is free of known copyright restrictions.

Glossary:

- Circulars - letters or advertisements which are distributed to a large number of people.
- Council of Defense - The Council of National Defense was a United States government organization formed during World War I to coordinate resources and industry in support of the war effort, including the coordination of transportation, industrial and farm production, financial support for the war, and public morale. States formed their own Councils of Defense to coordinate local efforts.

Questions:

1. Compare this community's approach to the epidemic to your own. What services did the community provide to victims of the illness? How did the city government intervene?
2. What do we learn about attitudes toward gender and women from this document?

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